Monthly Travel Indicators Summary

August 2026

October 8, 2026

About the Monthly Travel Indicators Summary

The Monthly Travel Indicators Summary is a summary compilation of key indicators and statistics from a variety of Visit California and third-party data sets for the reporting month, including:

Visit California Sources	Third Party Sources
AirDNA	Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS)
CIC Research	Department of Homeland Security (DHS)
Cirium	Department of Labor
CoStar	NTTO
Future Partners	U.S. Energy Information Administration (EIA)
Tourism Economics	University of Michigan
YouGov	

Table of Contents

- Executive Summary
- Domestic Indicators
  - Macroeconomic
  - Forecast
  - Consumer Sentiment
  - Lodging
  - Airlift
- International Indicators
  - Forecast
  - Exchange Rates
  - Consumer Sentiment
  - Airlift/Arrivals
- Appendix
  - Lodging YTD Metrics

Executive Summary Domestic

Forecast (updated September 2026)

According to Tourism Economics' September forecast, California's visitor volume is projected to increase 1.8% in 2026, adding 4.9 million visits for a total of 276.3 million. Visitor spending is forecast to grow 4.7% to $166.3 billion. Tourism Economics' downside forecast captures risks from heightened geopolitical uncertainty, renewed increases in inflationary pressures, and financial market turmoil. Under this downside scenario, California's total visitor volume growth would slow to 1.1% in 2026.

- Domestic visitation is forecast to grow 1.8% in 2026 (and 1.2% under the downside estimate), with domestic visitor spending projected to reach $140.2 billion (+5.1% YoY).

Macroeconomic

U.S. macroeconomic indicators saw a slight re-acceleration in inflation and retail gas prices in August, accompanied by a modest pullback in consumer sentiment. Inflation rose slightly to 3.4%, while national gas prices averaged $4.19 per gallon. However, the labor market demonstrated solid strength, adding 162,000 net nonfarm jobs while the national unemployment rate held steady at 4.1%.

- The Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS) reported an August inflation rate of 3.4%, up slightly from 3.3% in July.
- The national average retail price for a gallon of gas was $4.19, up 13 cents from July. The average price in California was $5.57 per gallon, up 15 cents from July.
- The University of Michigan's U.S. Consumer Sentiment Index moved down to 51.7 for the month, following July's reading of 55.2.
- The economy gained 162,000 jobs in August, while the national unemployment rate remained flat at 4.1%.

Consumer Sentiment

Domestic traveler sentiment remained steady in August, anchored by strong long-term optimism and high enthusiasm for leisure travel. Overall trip costs and gas prices continued to serve as the top deterrents limiting travel frequency. While short-term budget priorities ticked up slightly nationwide, Californians demonstrated particularly high excitement for travel over the next 12 months.

- Consumer tracking from Future Partners showed that travel costs remained the primary barrier to travel, with 36% of U.S. travelers citing travel as "too expensive" and 31% citing gas prices as a limiting factor (33% and 26% among California residents, respectively).
- U.S. travelers expressed continued optimism regarding their long-term financial situation, with 47% feeling they will be "better off" a year from now (45% among California residents).
- American travelers continued to prioritize leisure travel in their budgets (63%), while 87% indicated a high level of excitement for leisure travel in the next 12 months (reaching 91% among California residents).
- In terms of competitive destination demand, 45% of American travelers (and 58% of California residents) said they were considering international leisure travel within the next 12 months. The California figure is up seven points from the July reading.

Executive Summary Domestic (continued)

Lodging

California's lodging sector maintained positive momentum in August, supported by solid rate gains and steady end-of-summer demand. Statewide RevPAR grew 6.3% year over year to $148, significantly outperforming national RevPAR growth of 2.0%. The San Francisco Bay Area, San Diego, and Los Angeles regions led performance gains. Group travel posted strong results, with demand up 8.0% and revenue up 9.3%. Short-term rentals also outperformed national trends, with RevPAR up 4.2% compared to a 0.6% decline nationwide.

- Hotel room demand in California grew 1.8% for the month, while room revenue rose 6.1% to $2.6 billion. Room demand has grown in each of the last nine months and is up 3.0% year to date.
- The state's monthly occupancy rate reached 73% (+2.0% YOY), with an ADR of $203 (+4.2% YOY) and RevPAR of $148 (+6.3% YOY). By comparison, overall U.S. RevPAR grew 2.0% for the month.
- Group room demand expanded 8.0% YOY, driving group room revenue up 9.3% to $411 million. San Diego County (+21.4%), San Francisco Bay Area (+18.2%), Los Angeles County (+15.1%), and Deserts (+13.4%) recorded the strongest group revenue gains.
- The occupancy rate for short-term rentals in California stood at 64% (+1.6% YOY). ADR grew 3.7%, and RevPAR expanded 4.2% (vs. -0.6% for the U.S. overall).

Airlift/TSA Screenings

Domestic airlift capacity to California expanded for a second consecutive month in August, while TSA checkpoint throughput experienced moderate contractions both statewide and nationally. Tourism Economics has noted that hotel demand continues to outpace air passenger volumes nationally, suggesting many travelers are choosing to drive rather than fly due to the fact airfares represent a significantly larger portion of travel budgets than gas costs.

- Nonstop domestic seat capacity to California destinations reached 10.2 million for the month, up 3.1% year over year.
- A total of 76.8 million passengers were screened at TSA checkpoints nationwide in August, down 4.4% compared with August 2025. California's 9.5 million airport screenings were down 5.3%.

Executive Summary International

Forecast (updated September 2026)

International visitation to California is forecast to increase 2.4% in 2026 to 16.8 million, with international travel spending projected to reach $26.0 billion (+2.3% YOY). Under Tourism Economics' downside scenario, international visitation growth would flatten to 0.0% in 2026.

Consumer Sentiment

International travel intent among consumers across Visit California's 13 priority markets remained stable in August. Consideration of travel to the U.S. has increased modestly over the last three months, suggesting some lift following World Cup events.

- International leisure travel intent averaged across the 13 priority markets stood at 42%, on par with August levels in 2025 and 2024.
- Averaged across priority markets, 14% of international consumers indicated they were considering travel to the U.S. in the next 12 months. The figure is up two points since May. California averaged 10% globally in August.
- YouGov did not issue an August update for specific travel barriers/price due to recent methodology updates.

Airlift/Arrivals

Total nonstop seat capacity from priority markets declined 9.0% while international nonresident air arrivals to California ports of entry contracted 6.7% in August. However, Canadian air arrivals turned positive (+3.0% YOY) for the first time in 21 months, while Mexican air arrivals expanded 7.4%. Most overseas markets experienced contractions, particularly across European gateways.

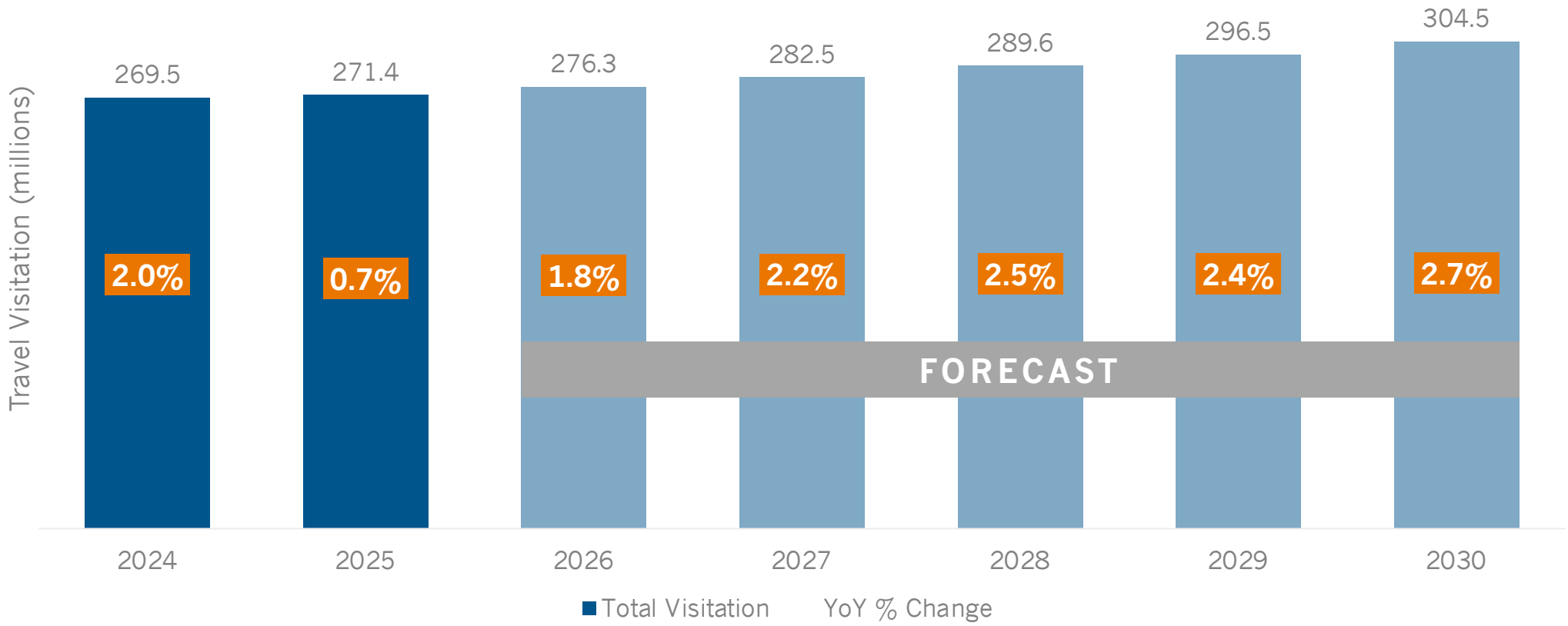
- Nonstop seats to California from the 13 priority markets totaled 1.5 million in August, down 9.0% year over year. Germany (+2.2%) and Japan (+0.3%) recorded minor seat additions. Air India flights now include a refueling stop and are no longer categorized as nonstop.
- Nonresident air arrivals from priority markets to California ports of entry totaled 488,800 in August, down 6.7% year over year (comparable to the overall U.S. decline of 6.8%).
- Canadian air arrivals rebounded into positive territory (+3.0% to 77,100), and Mexico (+7.4% to 67,900) continued to post solid gains.
- Contractions were recorded across most overseas markets, led by France (-26.5%), Middle East (-26.2%), Germany (-20.0%), India (-16.5%), South Korea (-11.1%), Japan (-8.5%), China (-7.6%), Australia (-6.8%), the U.K. (-3.3%), and Italy (-3.0%).

Domestic Indicators: Forecast

- Total Visitation & Spending Forecast
- Domestic Spending Forecast
- Baseline vs. Downside Forecast
- Lodging Forecast

California Visitation Forecast

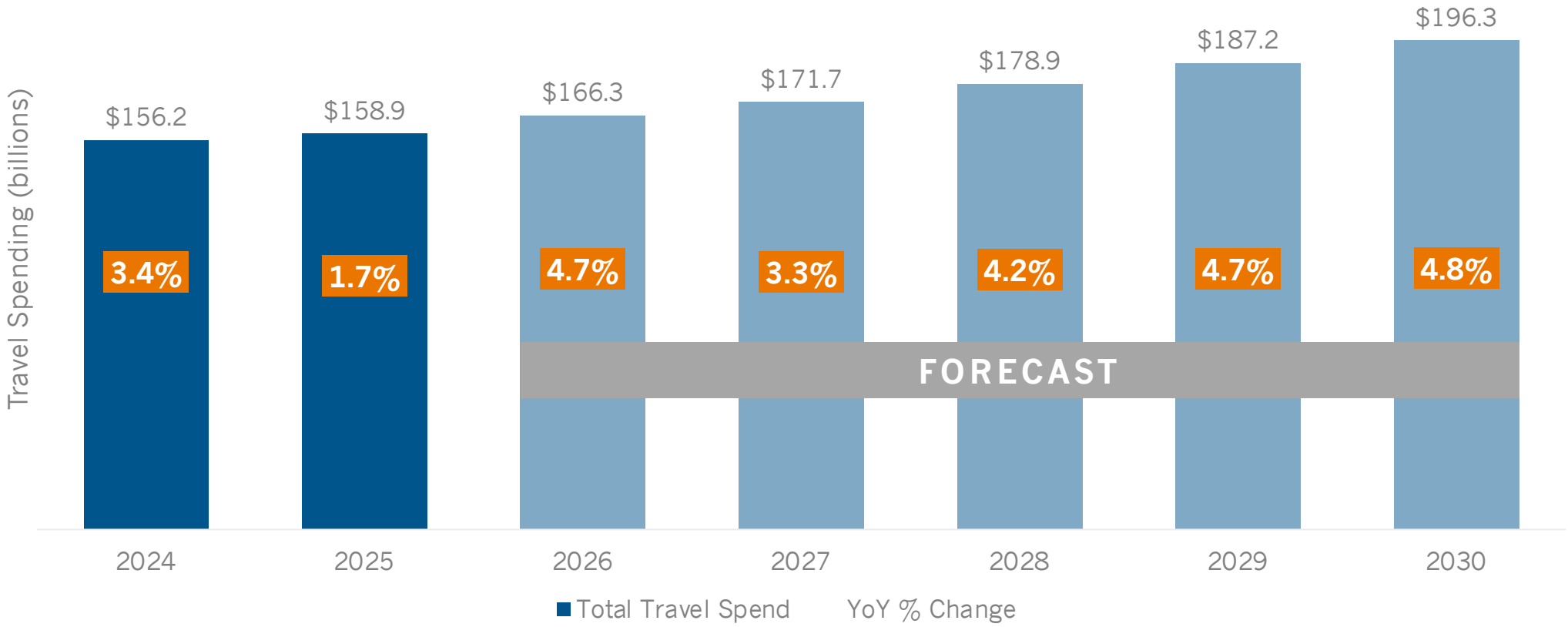
The chart below shows the current visitation forecast (domestic and international) and annual growth rates.



Source: Tourism Economics (September 2026)

California Spending Forecast

The chart below shows the current travel spending forecast (domestic and international) and annual growth rates.



Source: Tourism Economics (September 2026)

California Visitation Forecast: Domestic

The table below shows the current domestic visitation forecast and annual growth rates.

Visits (millions)	2025	2026	2027	YoY % Chg	2025	2026	2027
Total visits	**271.4**	**276.3**	**282.5**	**Total visits**	**0.7%**	**1.8%**	**2.2%**
Domestic total	**255.0**	**259.5**	**265.2**	**Domestic total**	**0.8%**	**1.8%**	**2.2%**
Business	40.8	41.8	43.4	Business	0.3%	2.3%	3.8%
Group	*7.3*	*7.4*	*7.7*	*Group*	*2.8%*	*1.9%*	*3.3%*
Leisure	214.2	217.8	221.8	Leisure	0.9%	1.7%	1.9%

Source: Tourism Economics (September 2026)

California Spending Forecast: Domestic

The table below shows the current domestic travel spending forecast and annual growth rates.

Spending (billions)	2025	2026	2027	YoY % Chg	2025	2026	2027
Total travel spending	**$158.9**	**$166.3**	**$171.7**	**Total travel spending**	**1.7%**	**4.7%**	**3.3%**
Domestic total	**$133.4**	**$140.2**	**$144.5**	**Domestic total**	**2.5%**	**5.1%**	**3.0%**
Business	$28.7	$30.5	$31.9	Business	1.3%	6.3%	4.5%
Group	*$5.1*	*$5.4*	*$5.6*	*Group*	3.9%	5.9%	3.8%
Leisure	$104.7	$109.7	$112.6	Leisure	2.9%	4.8%	2.6%

Source: Tourism Economics (September 2026)

2026 Baseline vs. Downside Forecast

The chart below shows the domestic downside forecast compared to the baseline forecast.

Visitation		
	2026 Baseline	2026 Downside
Total	**1.8%**	**1.1%**
Domestic	1.8%	1.2%
Spending		
	2026 Baseline	2026 Downside
Total	**4.7%**	**3.4%**
Domestic	5.1%	4.0%

Source: Tourism Economics (September 2026)

California Lodging Forecast

The table below shows the current California lodging forecast and annual growth rates.

	2025	2026	2027	2028	2029
Levels					
Hotel supply (daily)	573,126	571,586	577,260	582,602	586,844
Hotel room demand (daily)	385,856	397,964	402,212	409,229	416,355
Occupancy	67.3%	69.6%	69.7%	70.2%	70.9%
ADR	$190.65	$199.78	$201.94	$205.43	$209.06
RevPAR	$128.35	$139.10	$140.70	$144.30	$148.32
Room revenue (billions)	$26.9	$29.0	$29.6	$30.7	$31.8

	2025	2026	2027	2028	2029
Growth					
Hotel supply (daily)	0.5%	-0.3%	1.0%	0.9%	0.7%
Hotel room demand (daily)	0.8%	3.1%	1.1%	1.7%	1.7%
Occupancy	0.4%	3.4%	0.1%	0.8%	1.0%
ADR	1.2%	4.8%	1.1%	1.7%	1.8%
RevPAR	1.6%	8.4%	1.2%	2.6%	2.8%
Room revenue (billions)	2.1%	8.1%	2.2%	3.5%	3.5%

Source: Tourism Economics (Sept 2026)

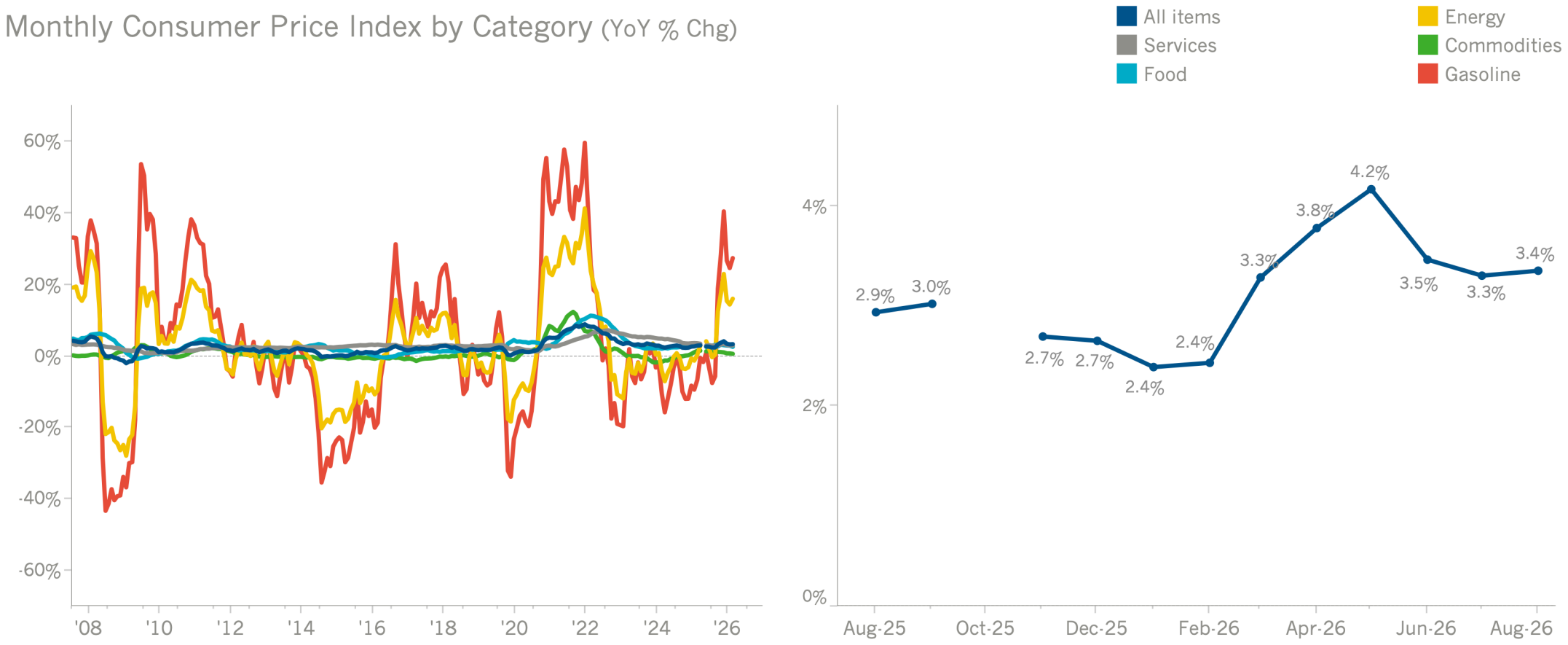
Domestic Indicators:

Macroeconomic

- CPI
- Gas prices
- Jobs/unemployment rate
- Consumer sentiment

U.S. Inflation Rate

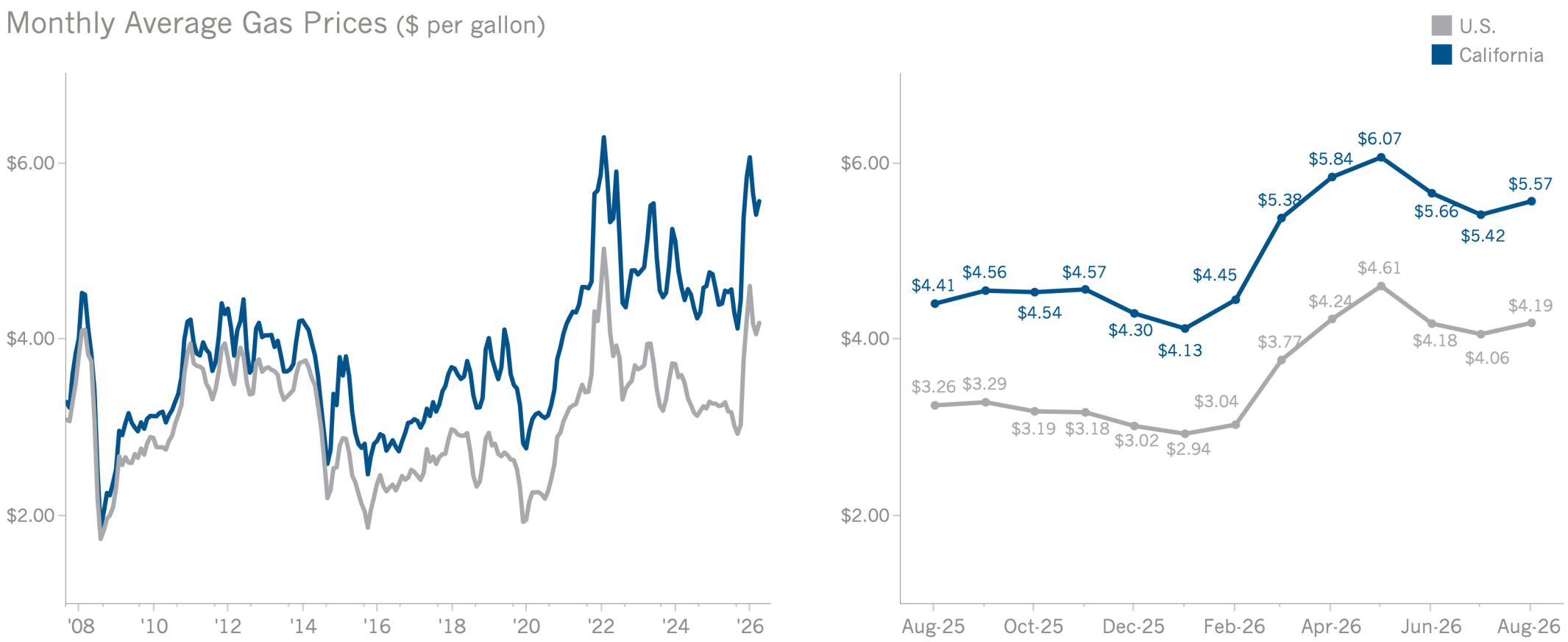
The charts below show the national Consumer Price Index as a percent change compared to same month in the prior year.



Source: Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS)

U.S. & California Gas Prices

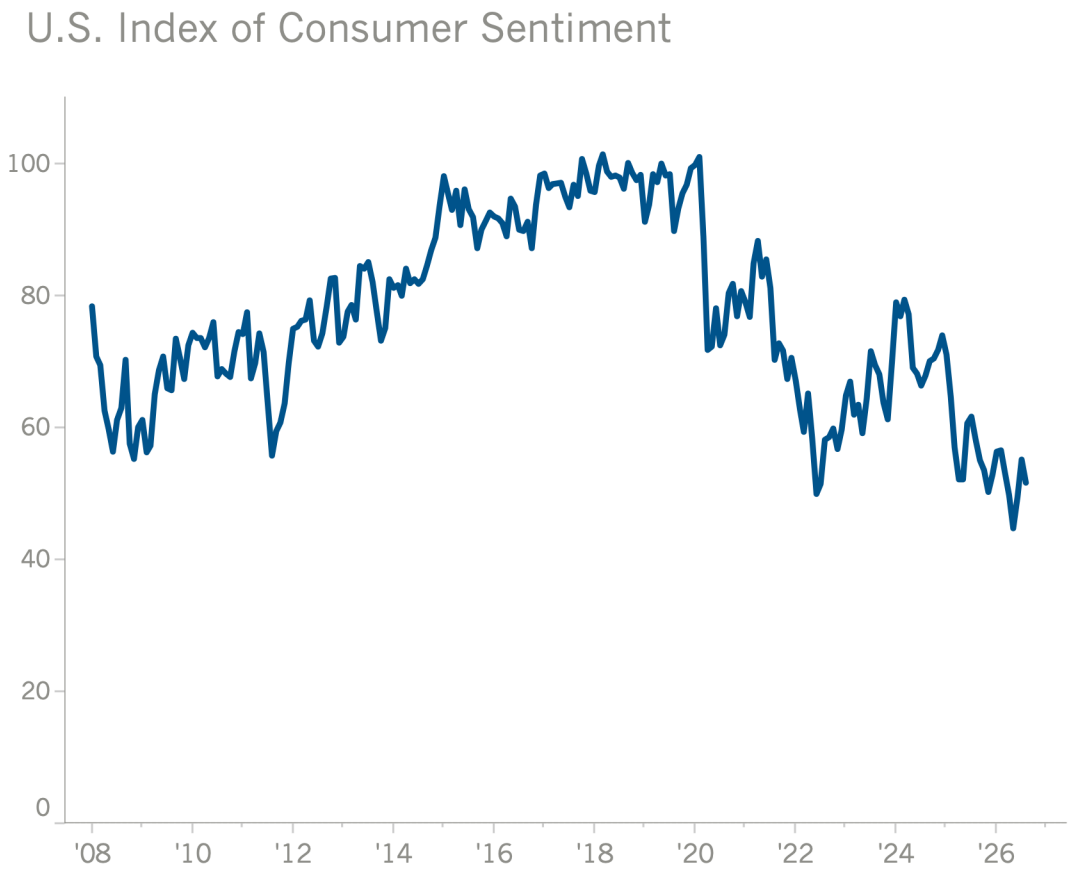
The charts below show the U.S. and California monthly average retail gas prices for all grades.

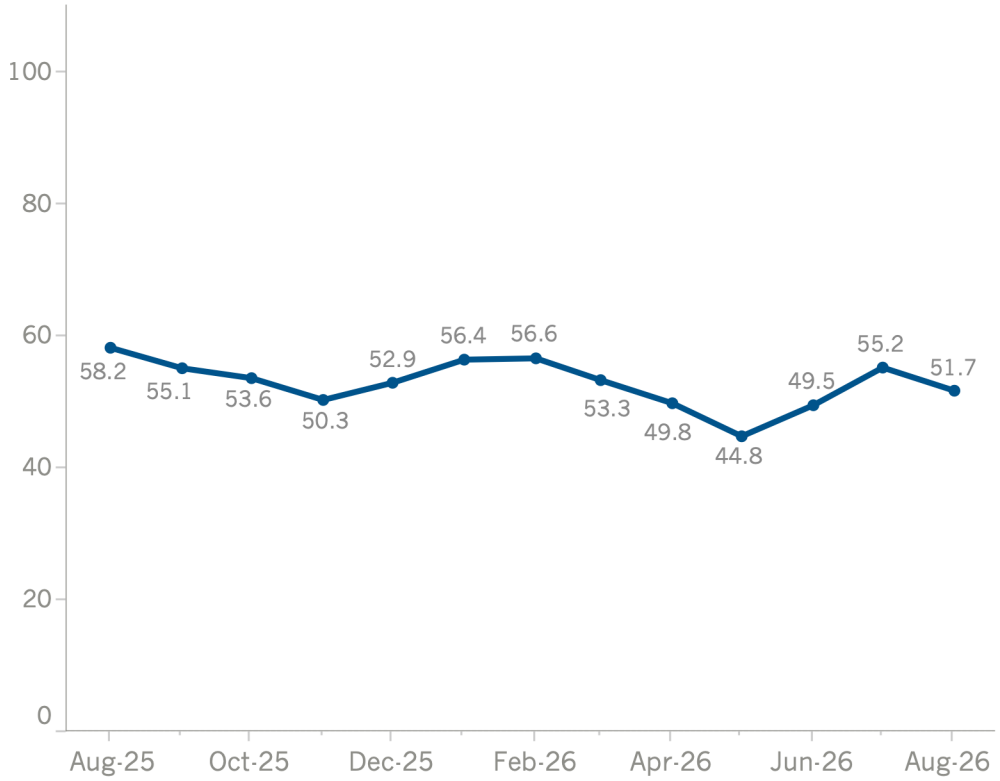


Source: U.S. Energy Information Administration (EIA)

U.S. Economic Consumer Sentiment

The charts below show the U.S. monthly consumer sentiment about the economy as an index.



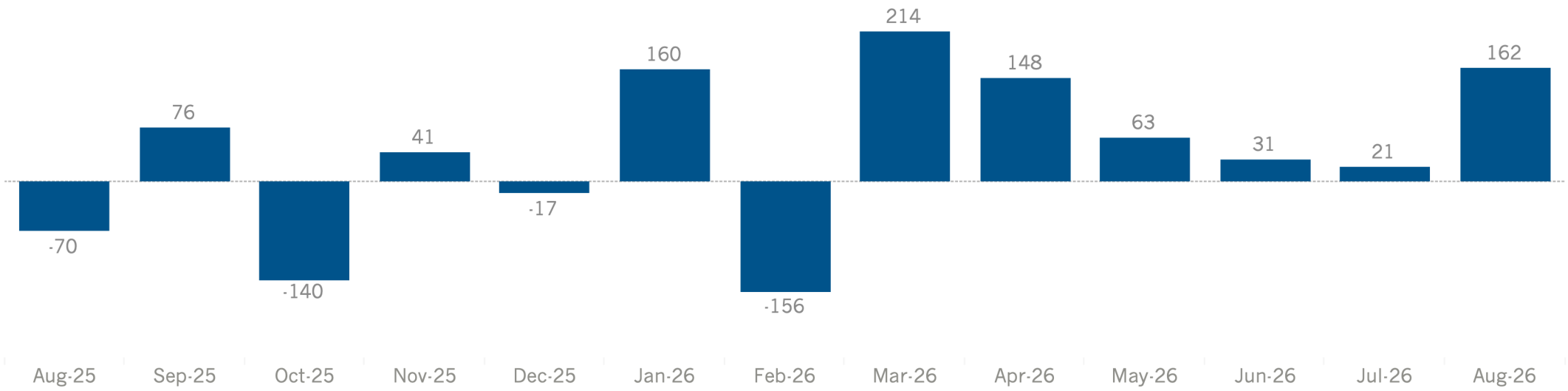


Source: University of Michigan

U.S. Jobs Added/Lost & Unemployment Rate

The chart below shows the net U.S. nonfarm jobs gained or lost for the month and the table shows the U.S. unemployment rate.

U.S. Net Jobs Added/Lost from Prior Month ('000)



U.S. Unemployment Rate (%)

4.3%	4.4%		4.6%	4.4%	4.3%	4.4%	4.3%	4.3%	4.3%	4.2%	4.1%	4.1%

Source: Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS)

Domestic Indicators:

Consumer Sentiment

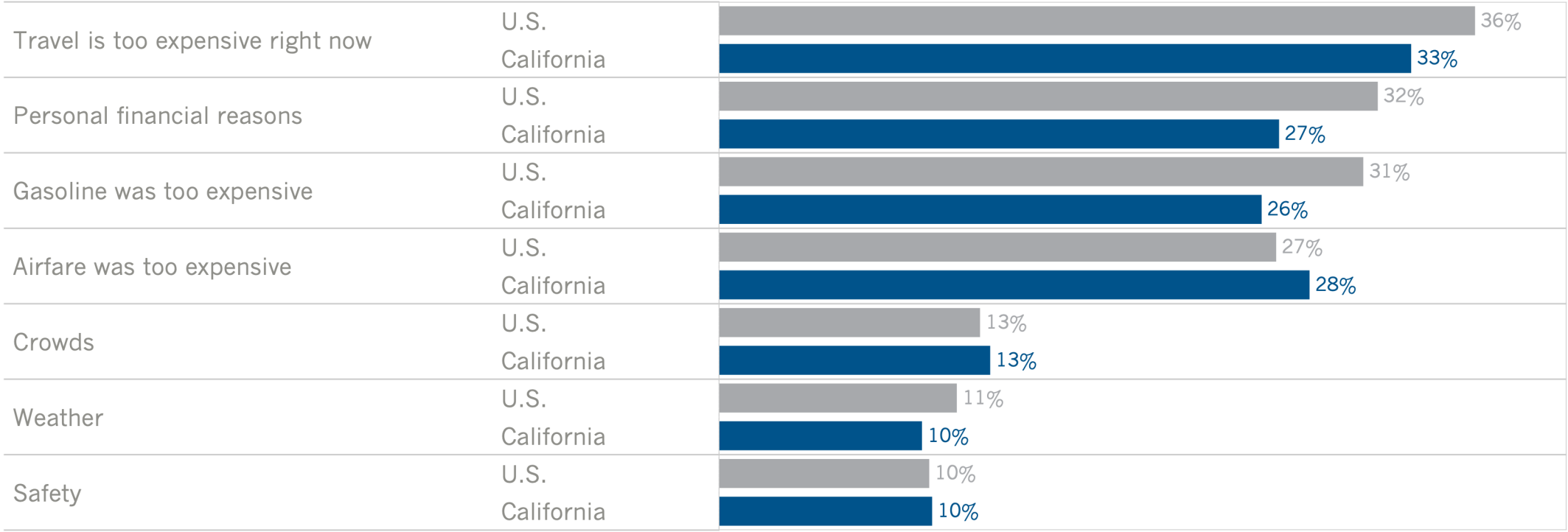
- Travel deterrents
- Perceptions of financial situation
- Travel as a budget priority
- Excitement for travel
- International travel intent

U.S. & California Travel Deterrents

The chart below shows travel deterrents among U.S. and California traveling consumers in the past 6 months.

Travel Deterrents (August 2026)

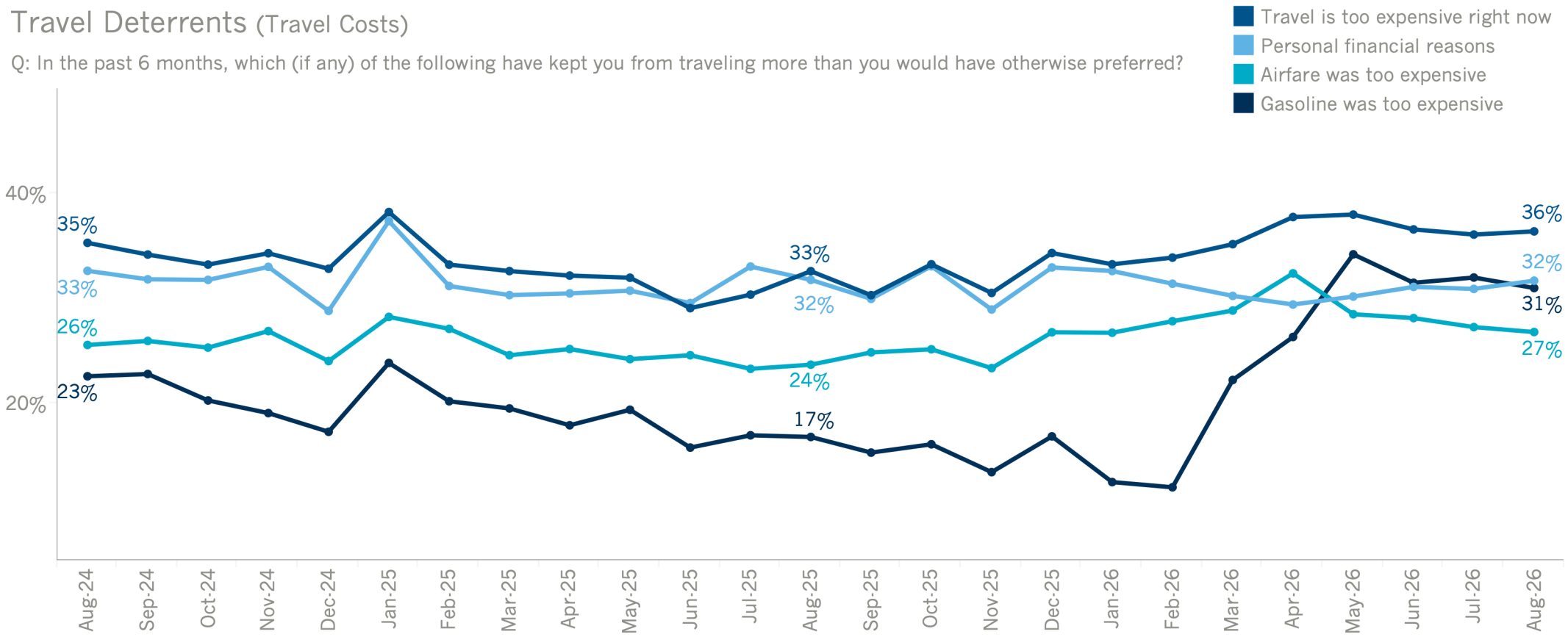
Q: In the past 6 months, which (if any) of the following have kept you from traveling more than you would have otherwise preferred?



Source: Future Partners, *The State of the American Traveler*

U.S. Travel Deterrents- Travel Costs

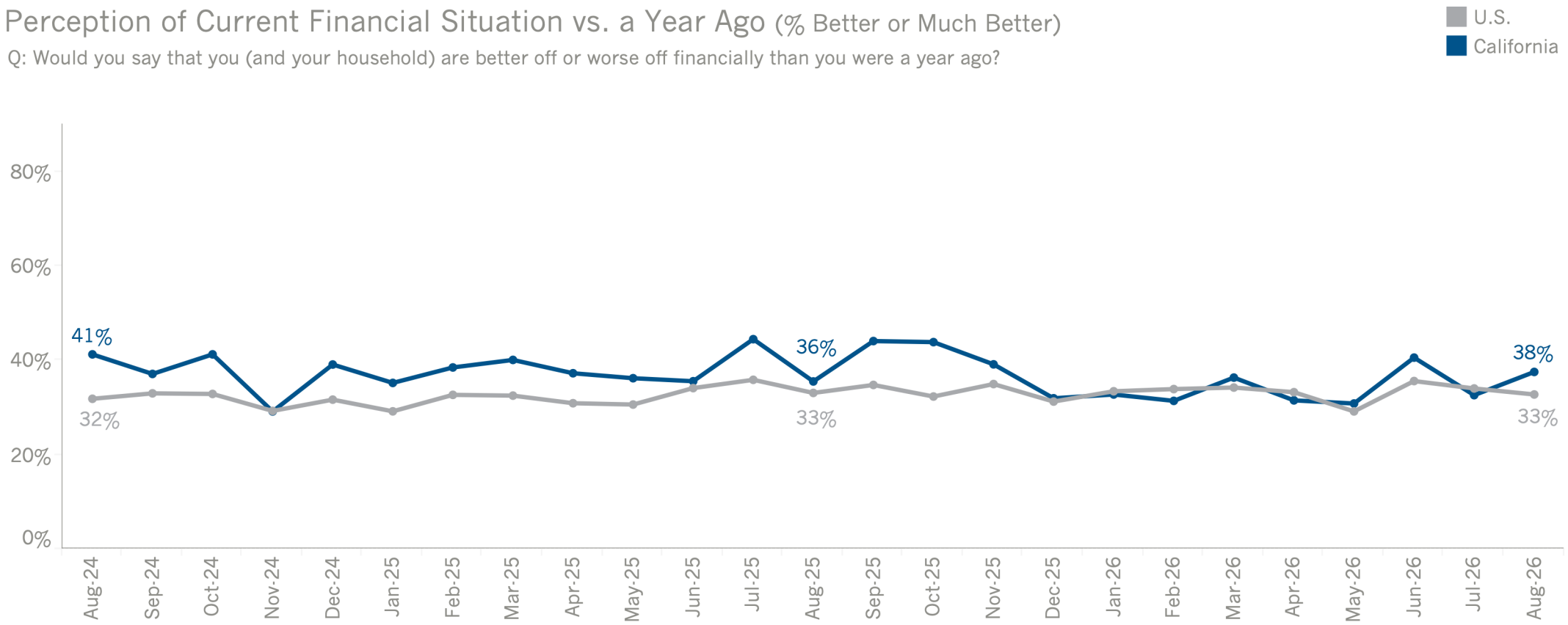
The chart below shows travel deterrents among U.S. traveling consumers in the past 6 months.



Source: Future Partners, *The State of the American Traveler*

U.S. & California Current Financial Situation

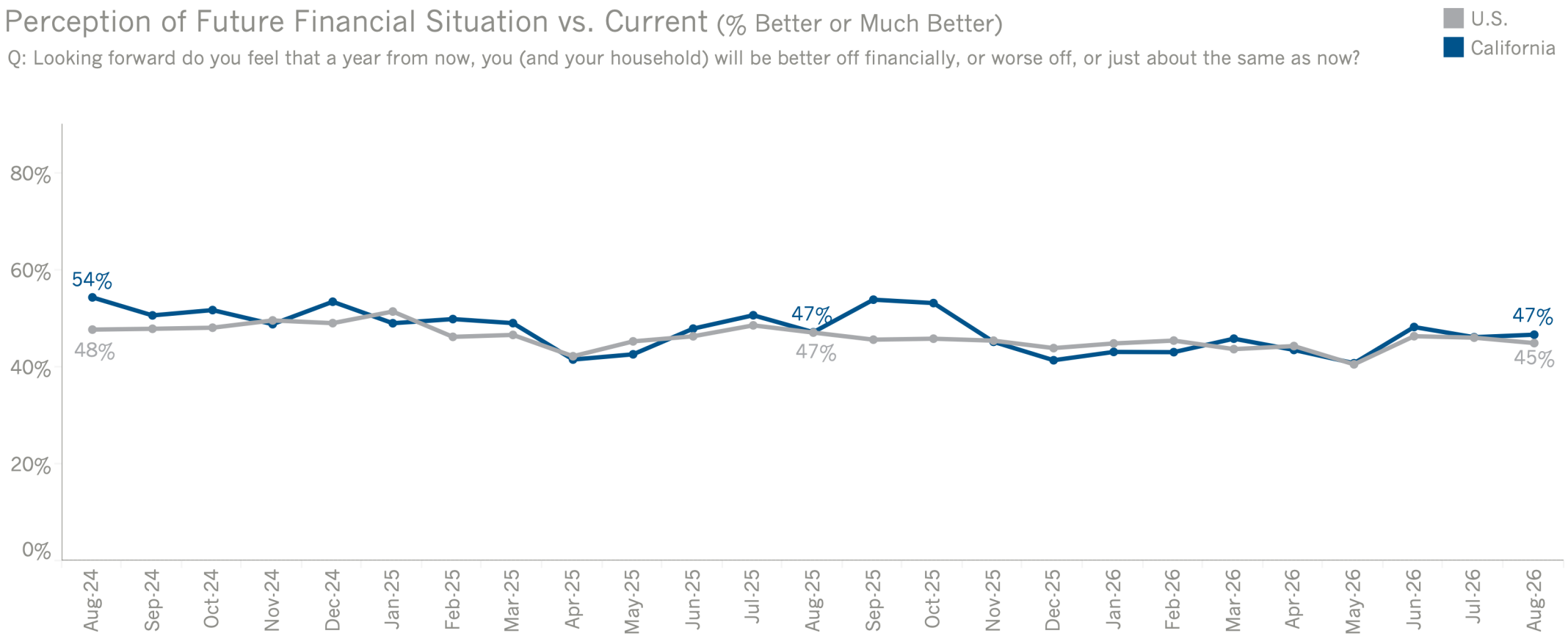
The chart below shows perception of current financial situation (vs. a year ago) among U.S. and California traveling consumers.



Source: Future Partners, *The State of the American Traveler*

U.S. & California Future Financial Situation

The chart below shows perception of future financial situation among U.S. and California traveling consumers.



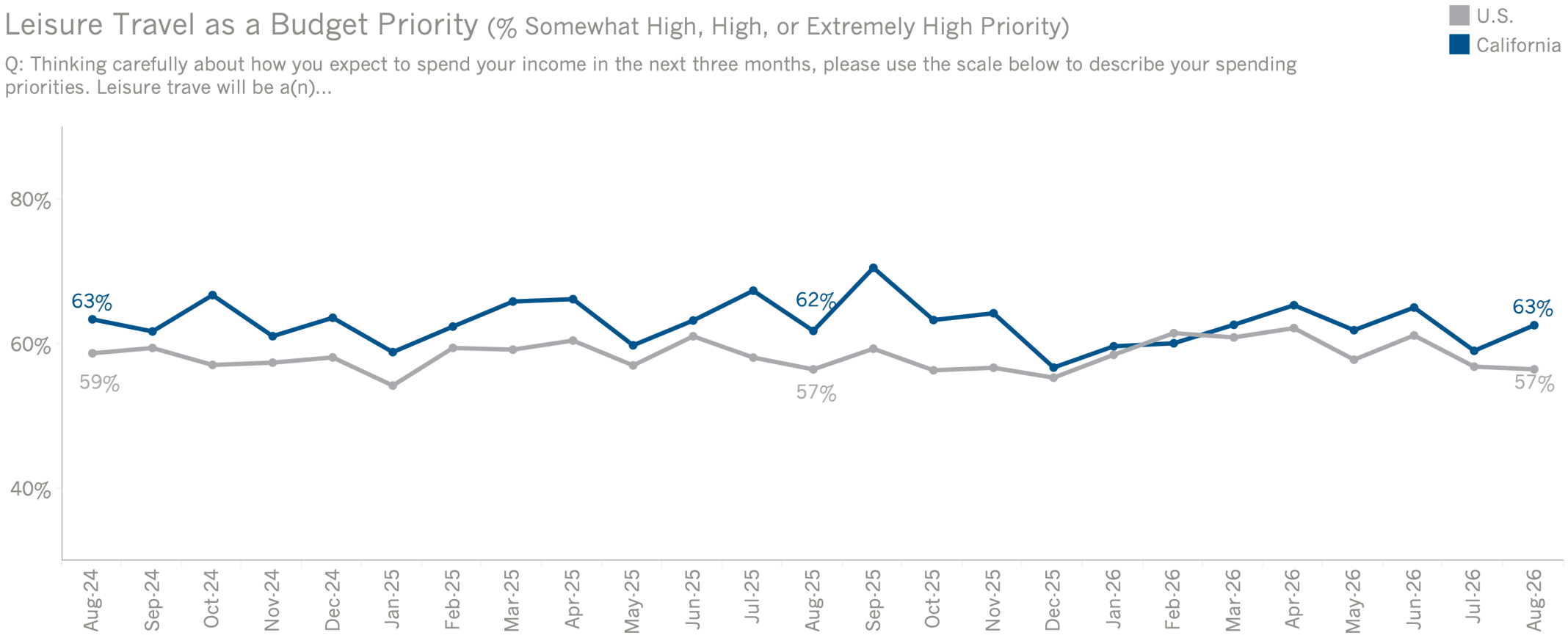
Source: Future Partners, *The State of the American Traveler*

U.S. & California Budget Priorities

The chart below shows perception of leisure travel as a budget priority among U.S. and California traveling consumers.

Leisure Travel as a Budget Priority (% Somewhat High, High, or Extremely High Priority)

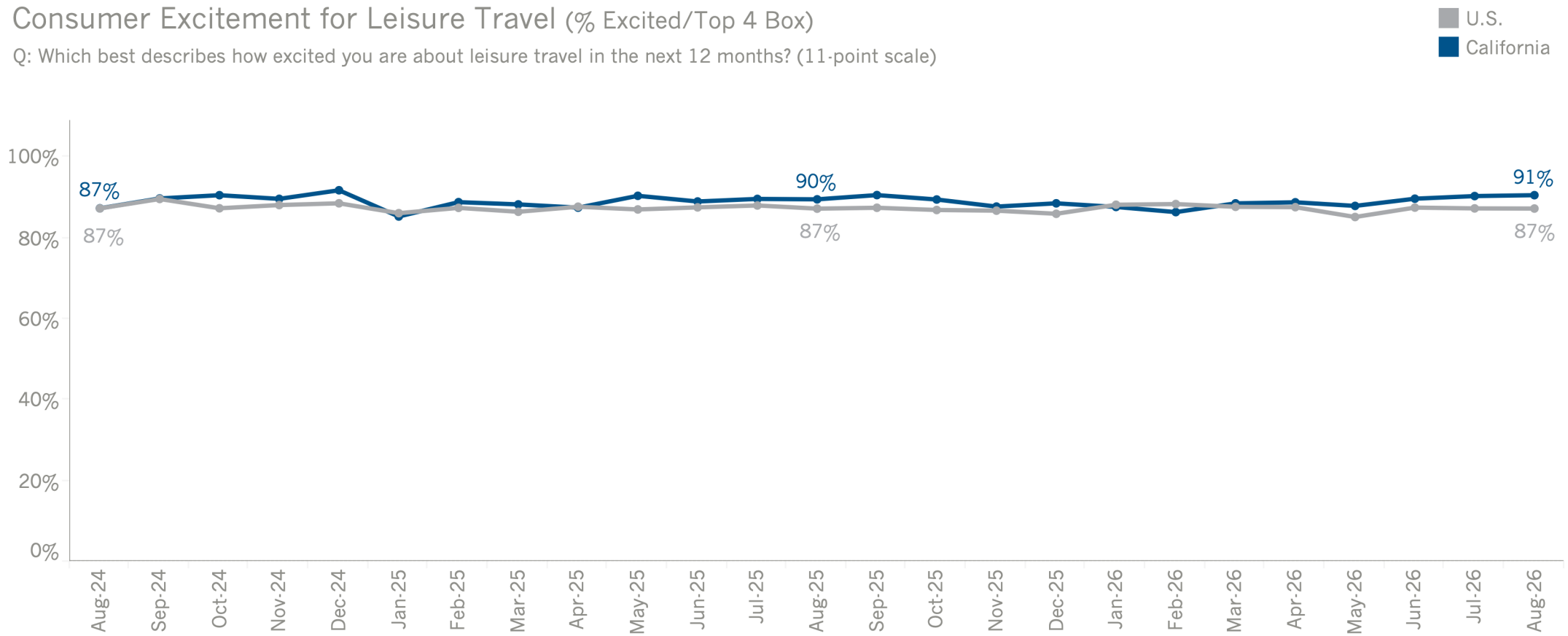
Q: Thinking carefully about how you expect to spend your income in the next three months, please use the scale below to describe your spending priorities. Leisure trave will be a(n)...



Source: Future Partners, *The State of the American Traveler*

U.S. & California Excitement for Travel

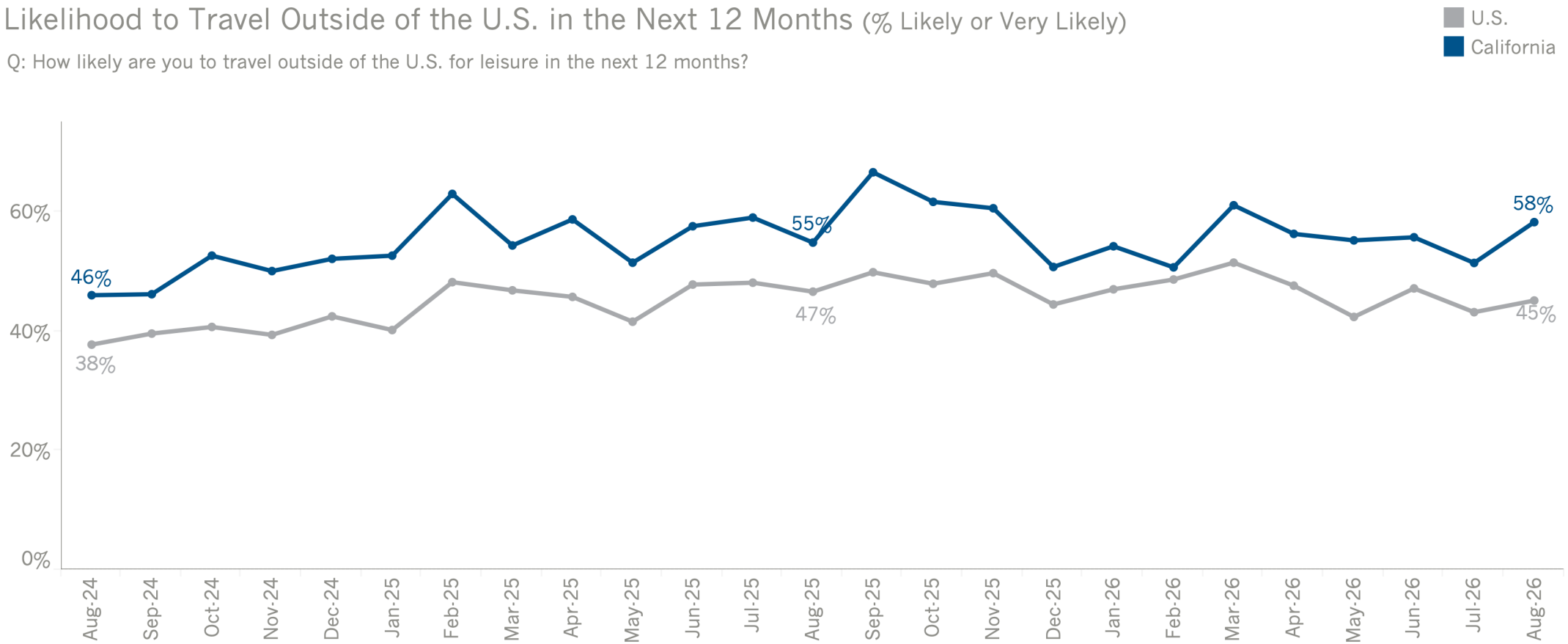
The chart below shows consumer excitement to travel in the next 12 months among U.S. and California traveling consumers.



Source: Future Partners, *The State of the American Traveler*

U.S. & California Int'l Leisure Travel Plans

The chart below shows consumer intent to travel outside the U.S. in the next 12 months among U.S. and California traveling consumers.



Source: Future Partners, *The State of the American Traveler*

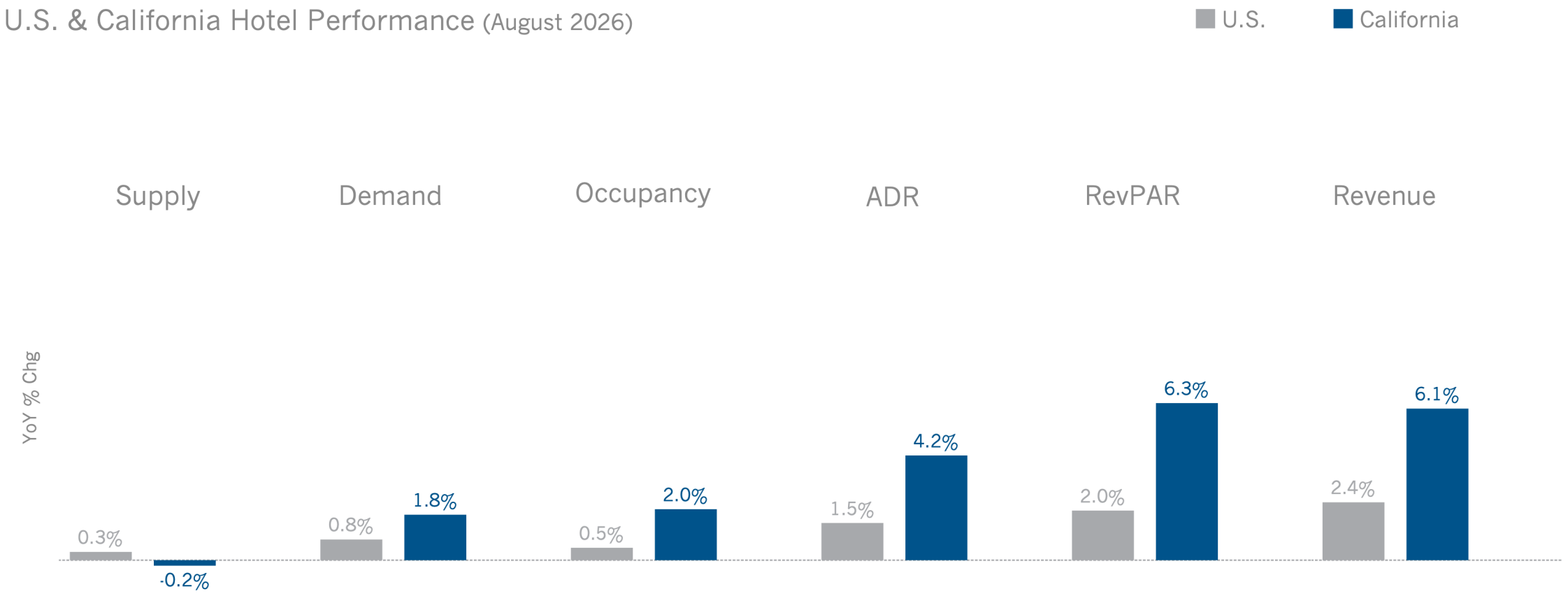
Domestic Indicators:

Lodging

- Room demand & revenue
- Monthly hotel performance metrics
- Group room demand & revenue
- Short term rental performance metrics

U.S. & California Hotel Performance

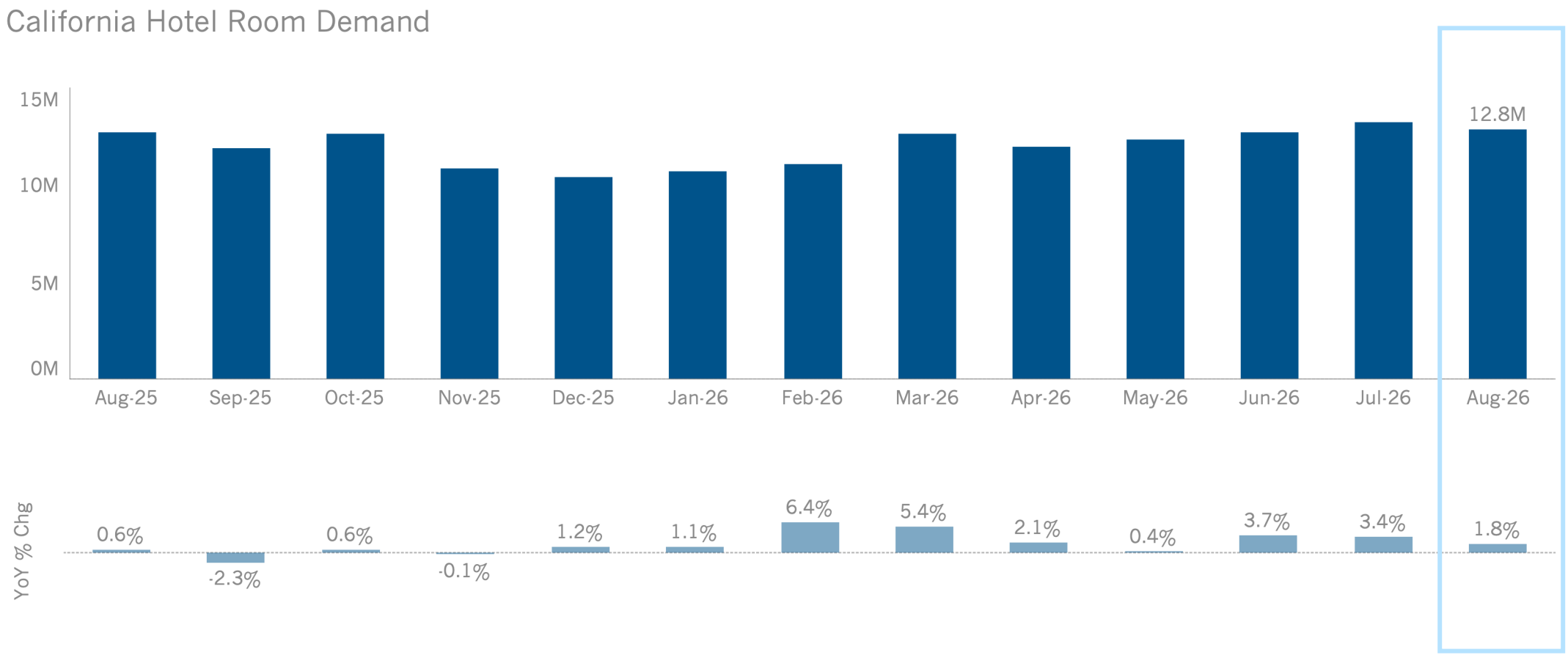
The chart below shows year-over-year performance for the U.S. and California for the reporting month.



Source: CoStar

California Hotel Room Demand

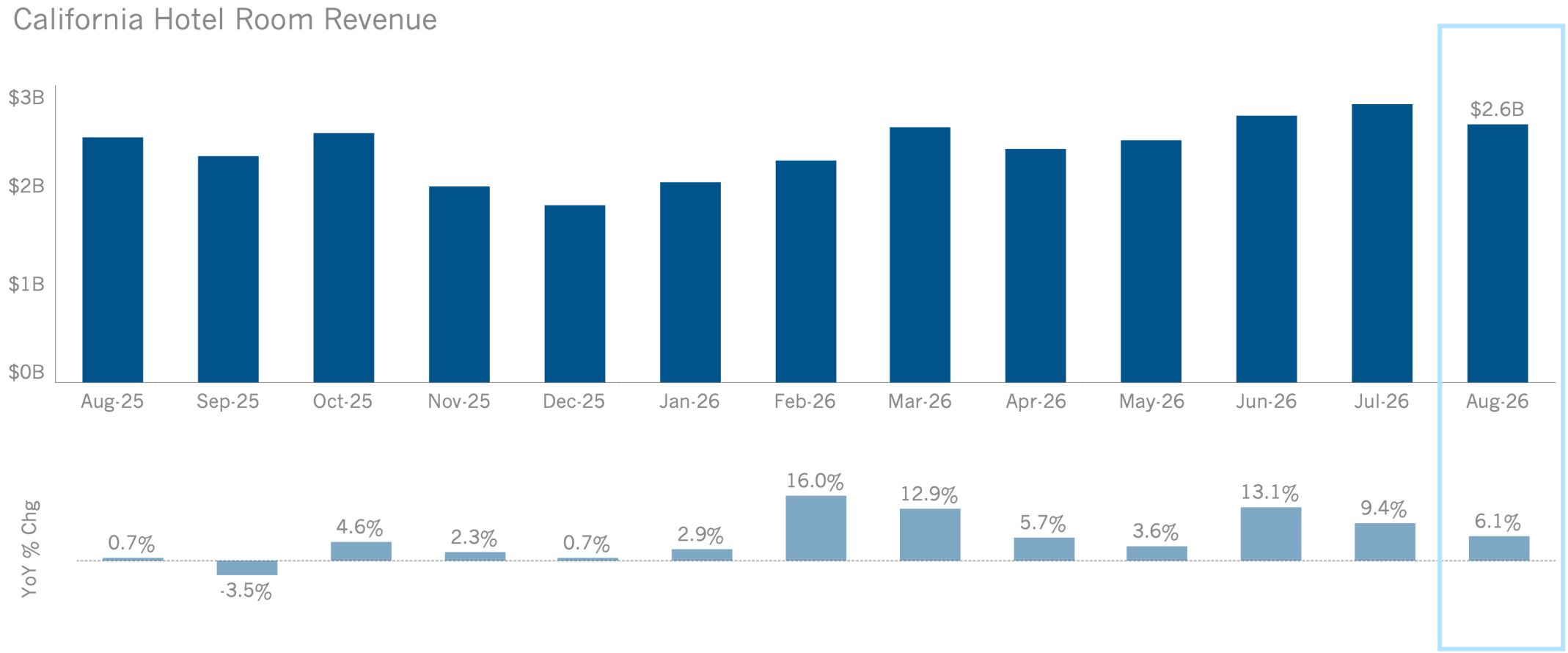
The chart below shows monthly California hotel room demand and percent change.



Source: CoStar

California Hotel Room Revenue

The chart below shows monthly California hotel room revenue and percent change.

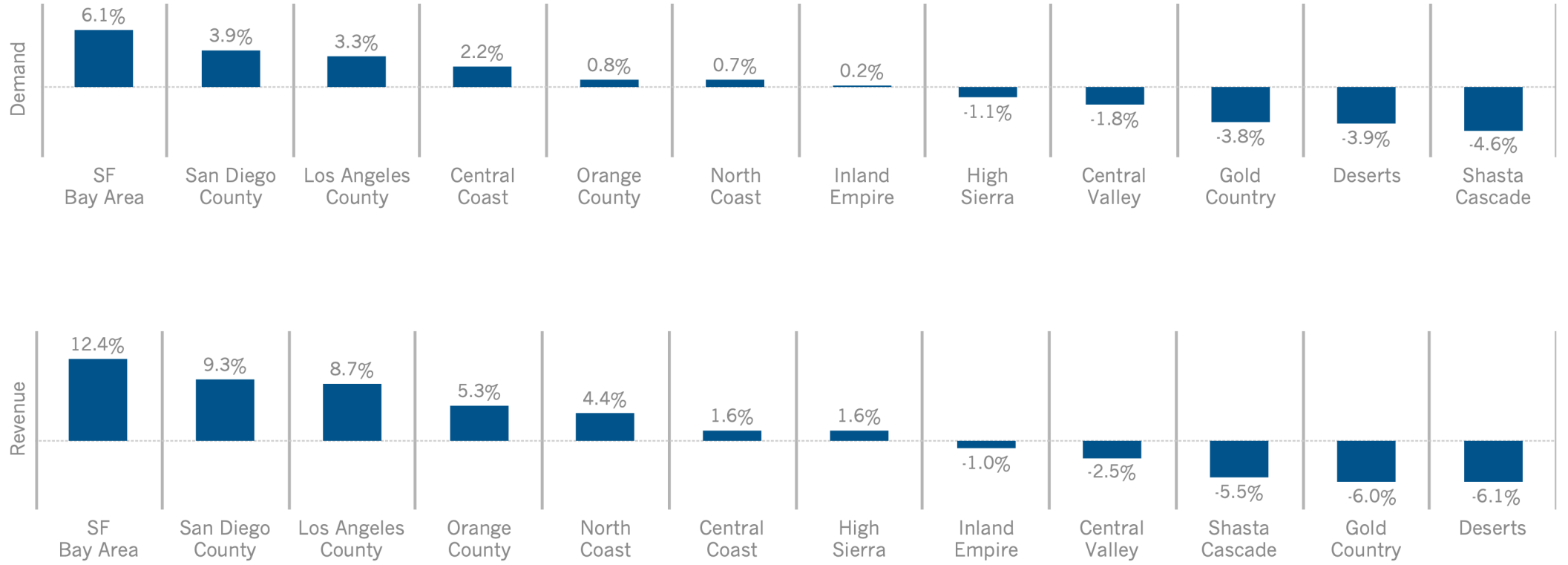


Source: CoStar

Regional Hotel Demand & Revenue Growth

The charts below show regional hotel room demand and revenue percent change to prior year for the reporting month.

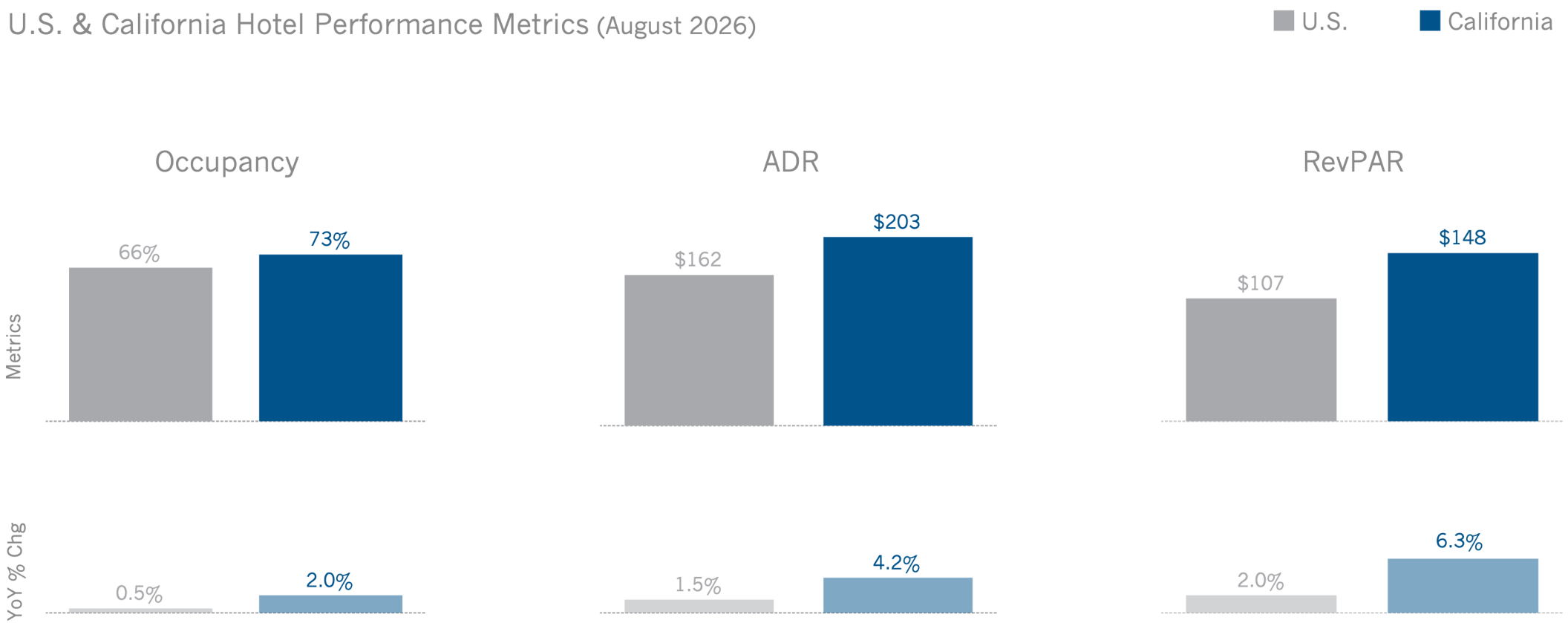
California Regional Hotel Room Demand & Revenue Growth (August 2026)



Source: CoStar

U.S. & California Hotel Performance Metrics

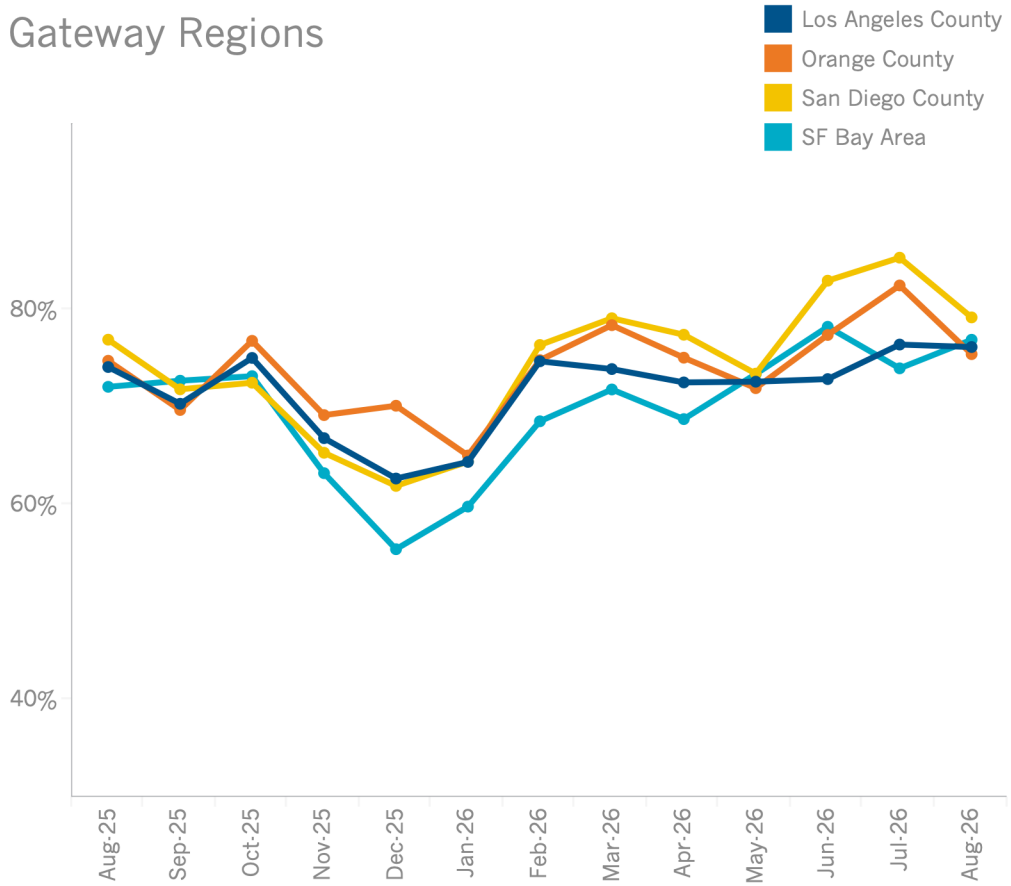
The charts below show key hotel metrics and percent change for the U.S. and California for the reporting month.

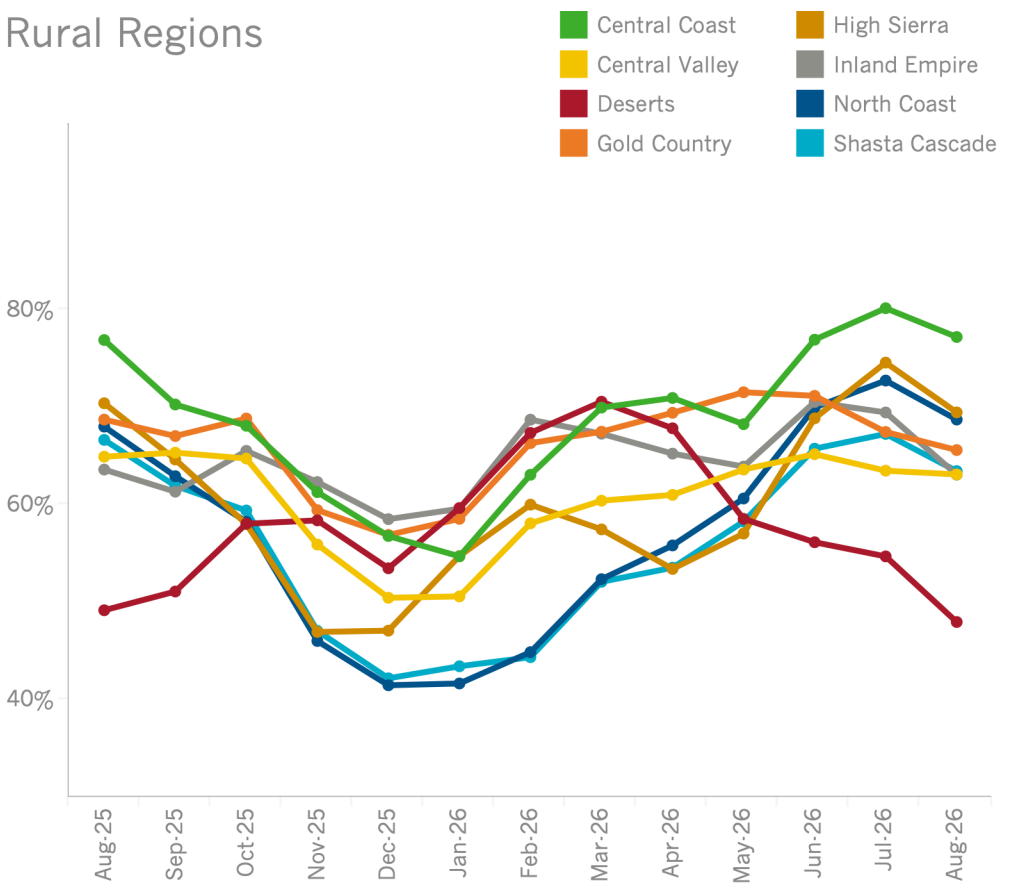


Source: CoStar

California Regional Hotel Occupancy

The charts below show monthly occupancy rates for gateway and rural tourism regions.

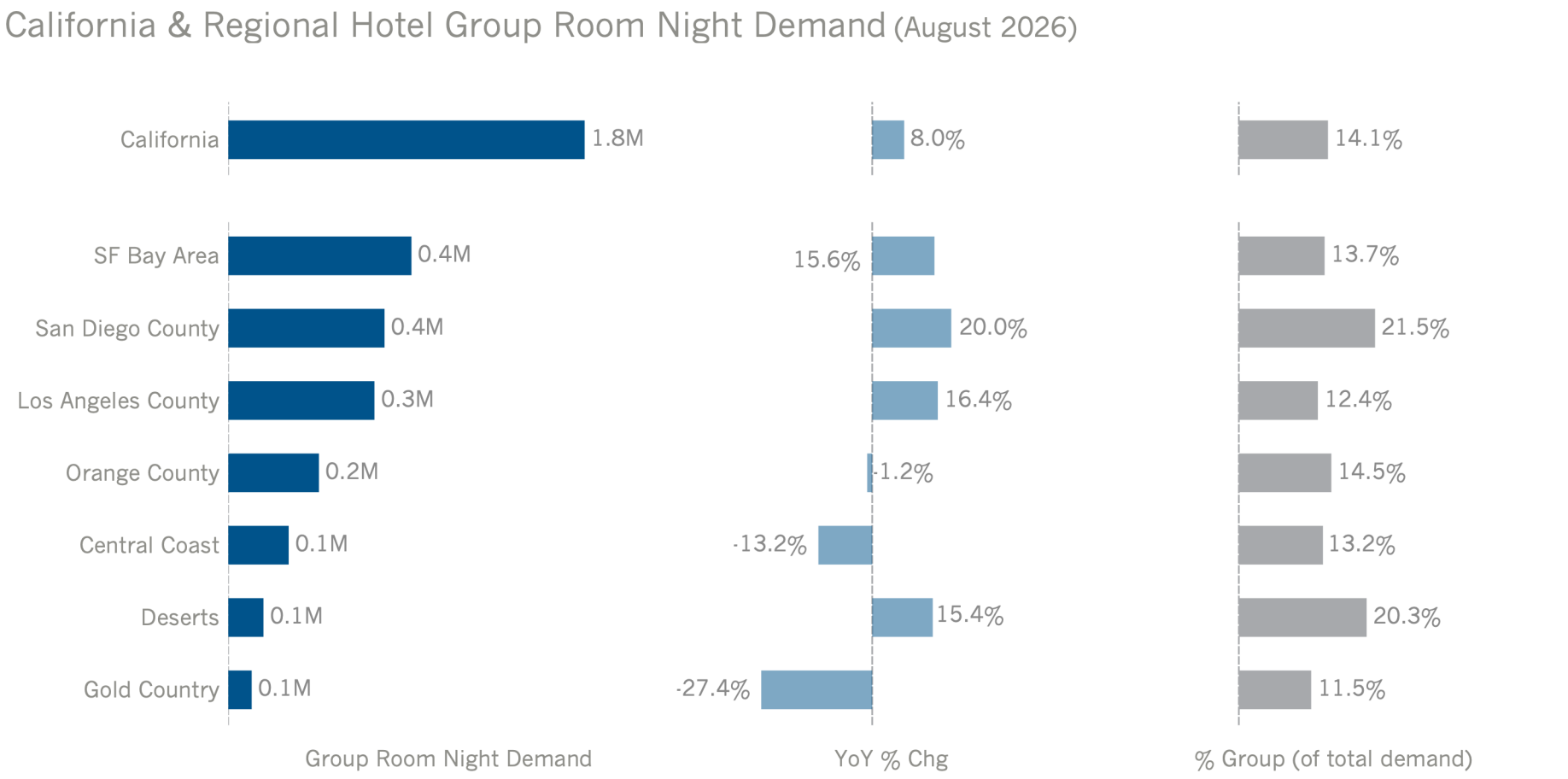




Source: CoStar

California Hotel Group Demand

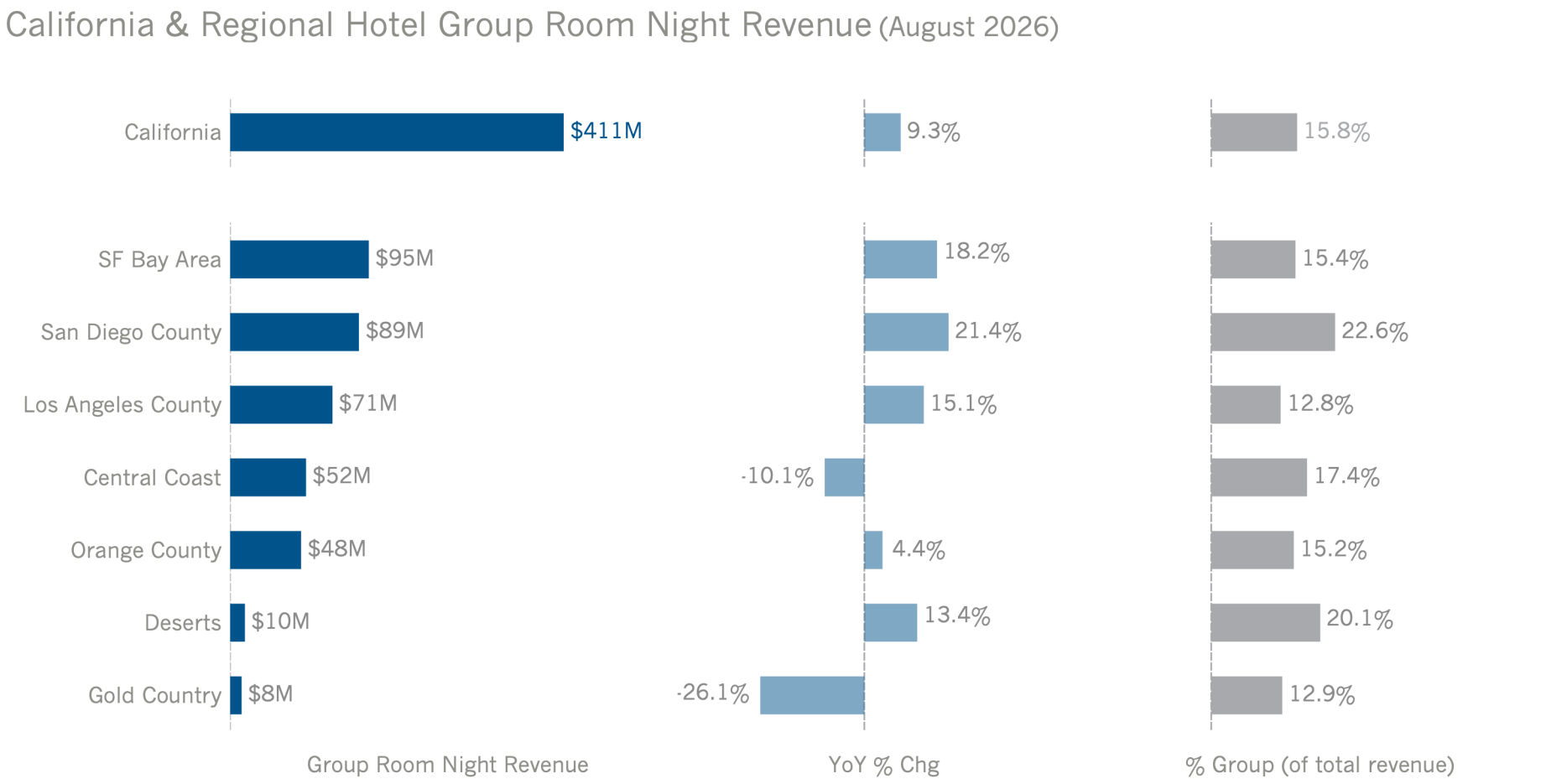
The chart below shows group room demand by market for the reporting month, percent change & percent of total demand.



Source: CoStar

California Hotel Group Revenue

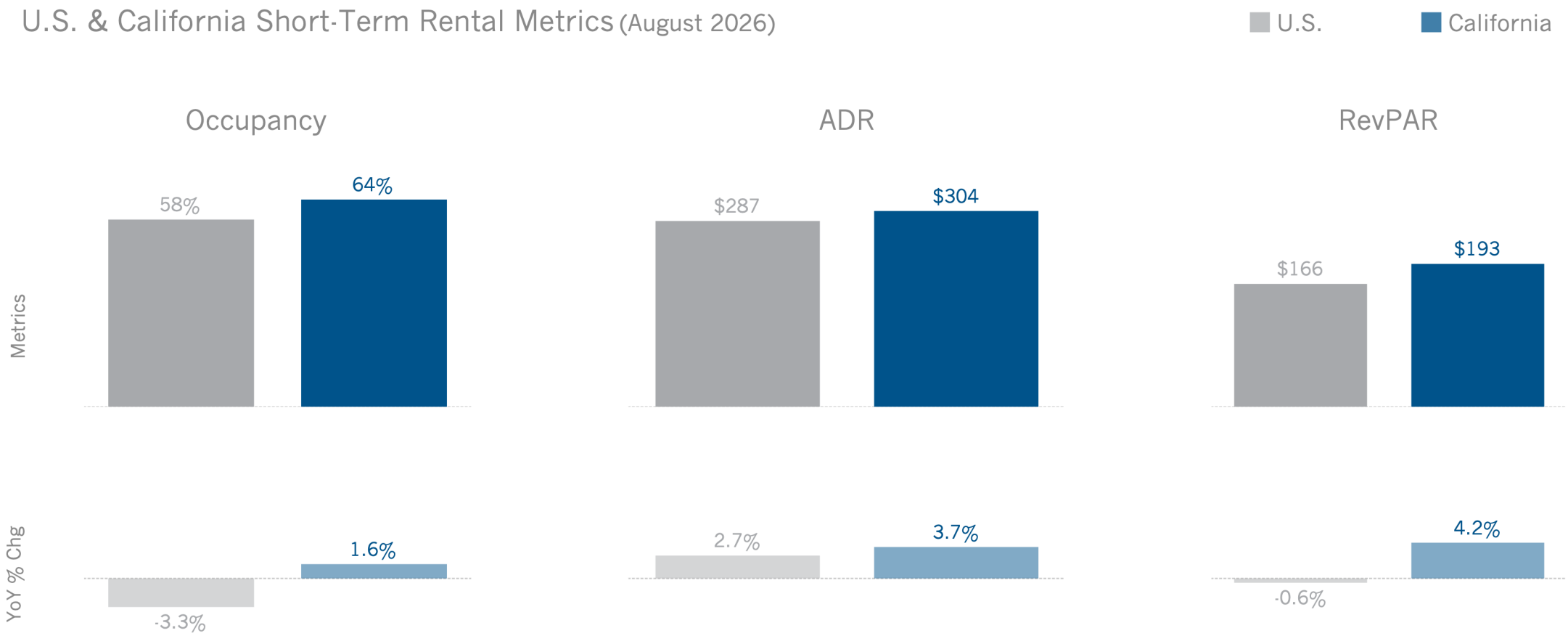
The chart below shows group room revenue by market for the reporting month, percent change & percent of total demand.



Source: CoStar

California Short-Term Rental Metrics

The chart below shows key short-term rental metrics and percent change for the U.S. and California for the reporting month.



Source: AirDNA

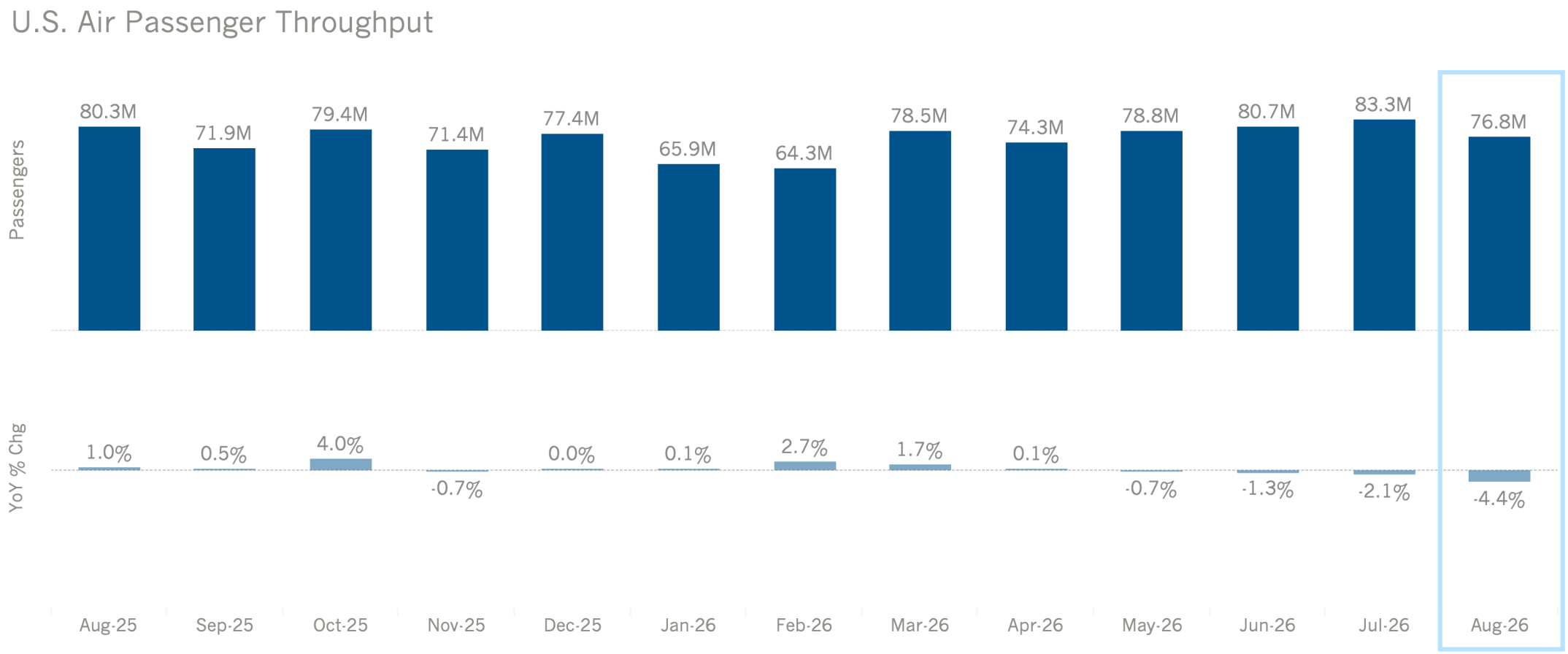
Domestic Indicators:

Airlift

- Air passenger throughput
- Domestic nonstop seats

U.S. Air Passenger Throughput

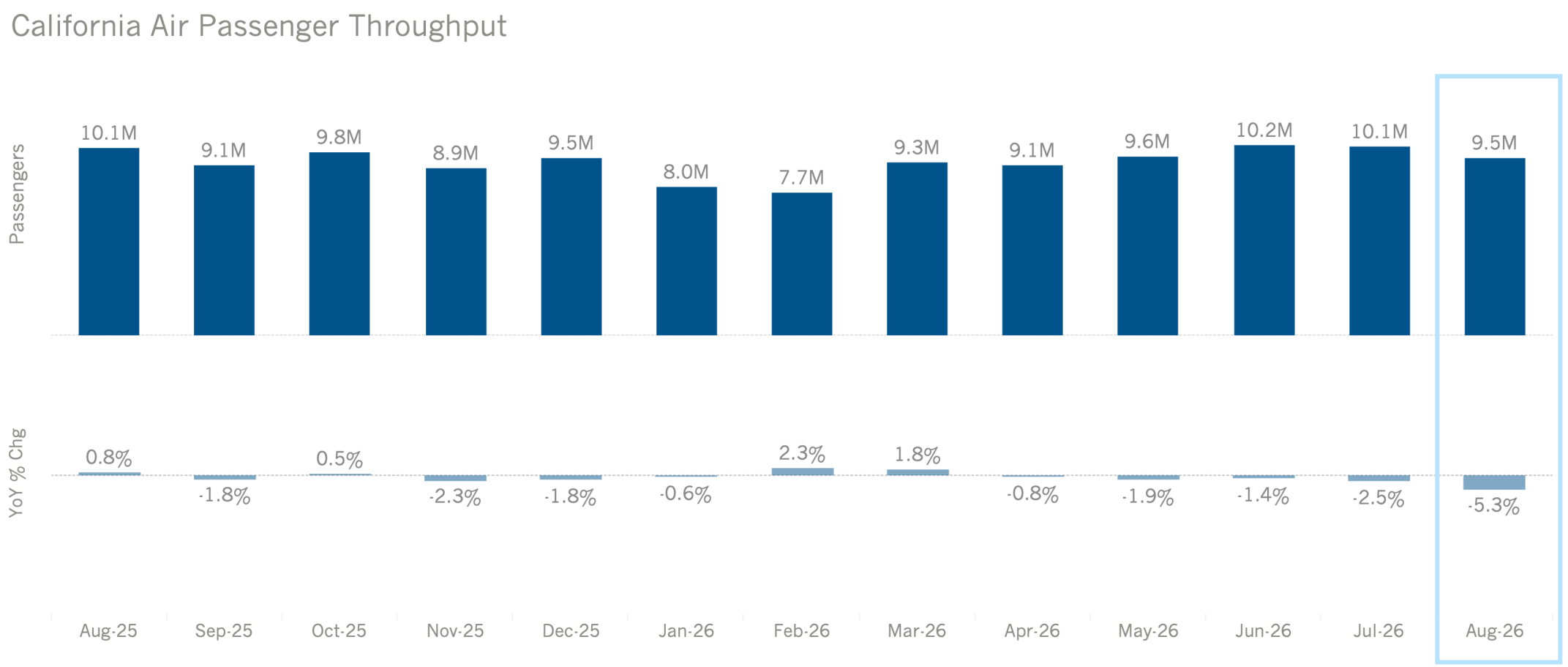
The chart below shows the monthly total number of passengers screened at TSA checkpoints in U.S. airports and percent change.



Source: Department of Homeland Security (DHS)

California Air Passenger Throughput

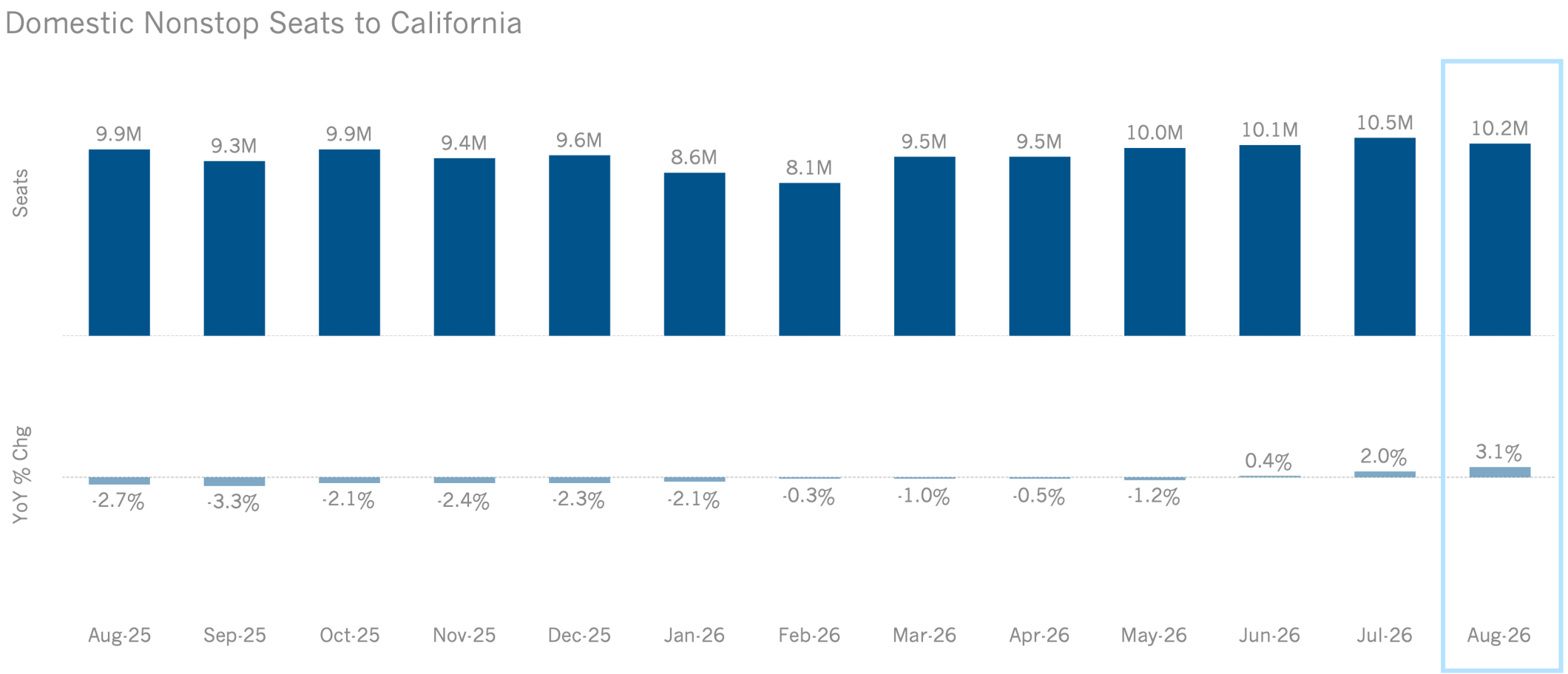
The chart below shows the monthly total number of passengers screened at TSA checkpoints in California airports and percent change.



Source: Department of Homeland Security (DHS)

Domestic Nonstop Seats

The chart below shows monthly domestic nonstop seats to California and percent change.



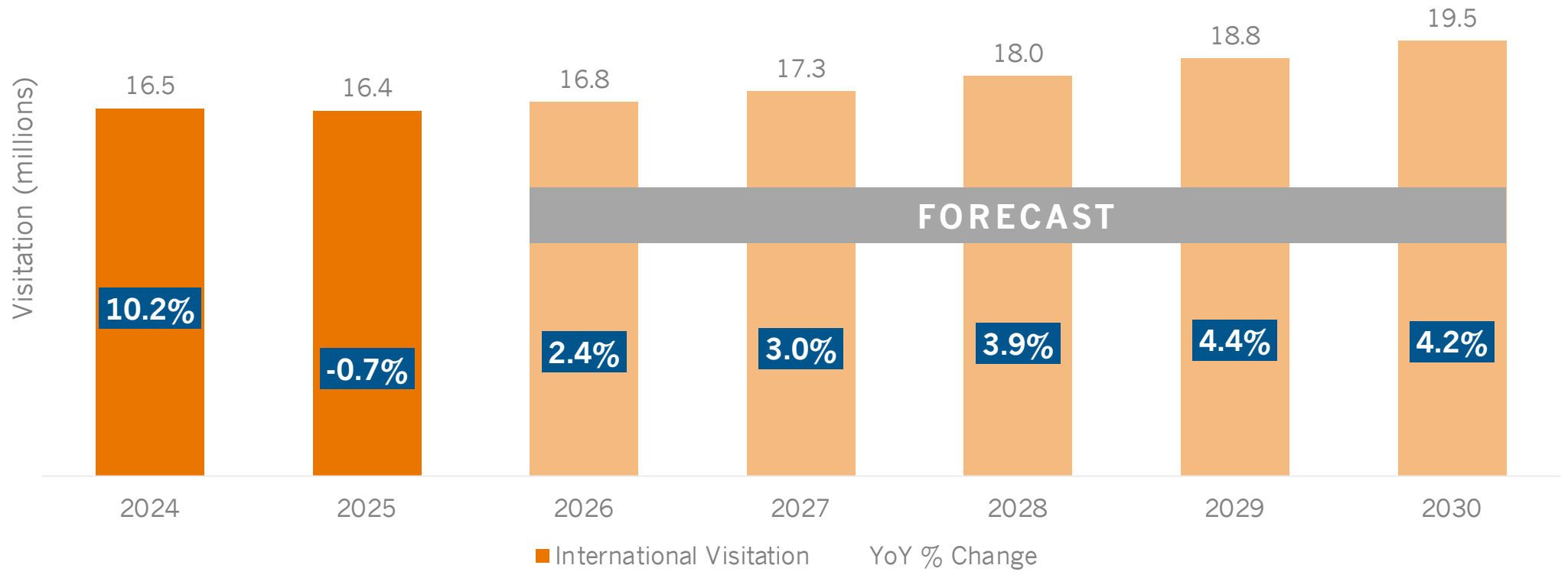
Source: Cirium

International Indicators: Forecast

- International Market Forecast

California International Visitation Forecast

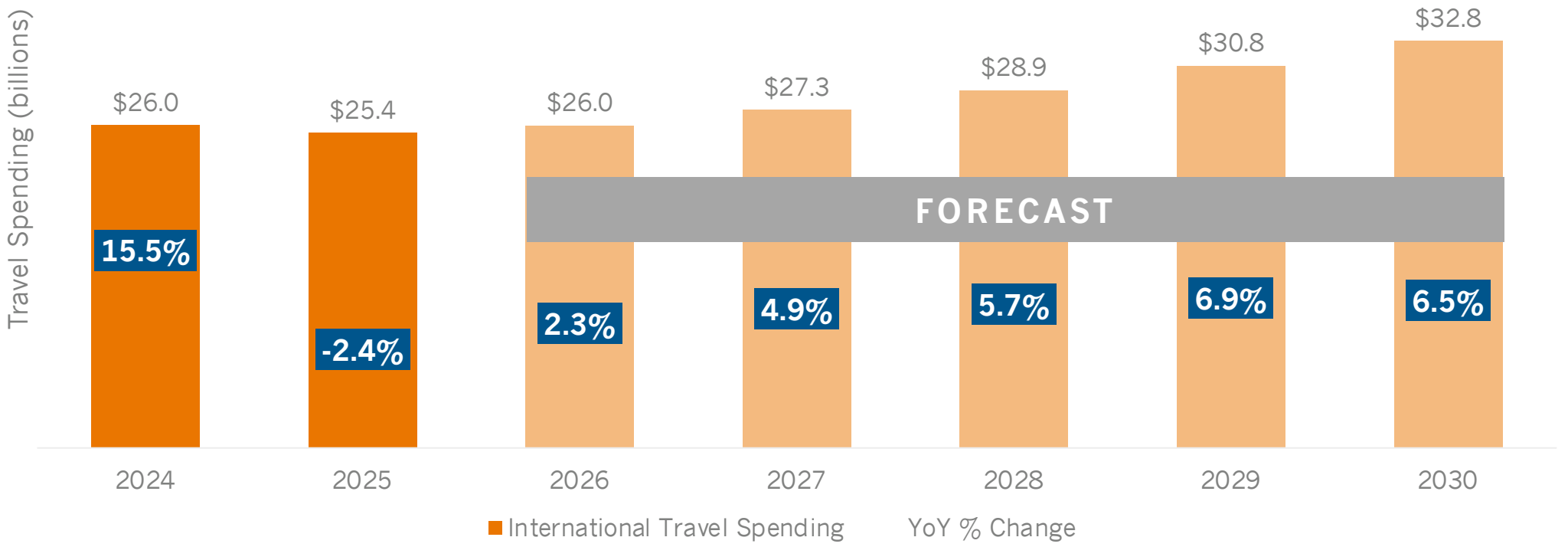
The chart below shows the current international visitation forecast and annual growth rate.



Source: Tourism Economics (September 2026)

California International Spending Forecast

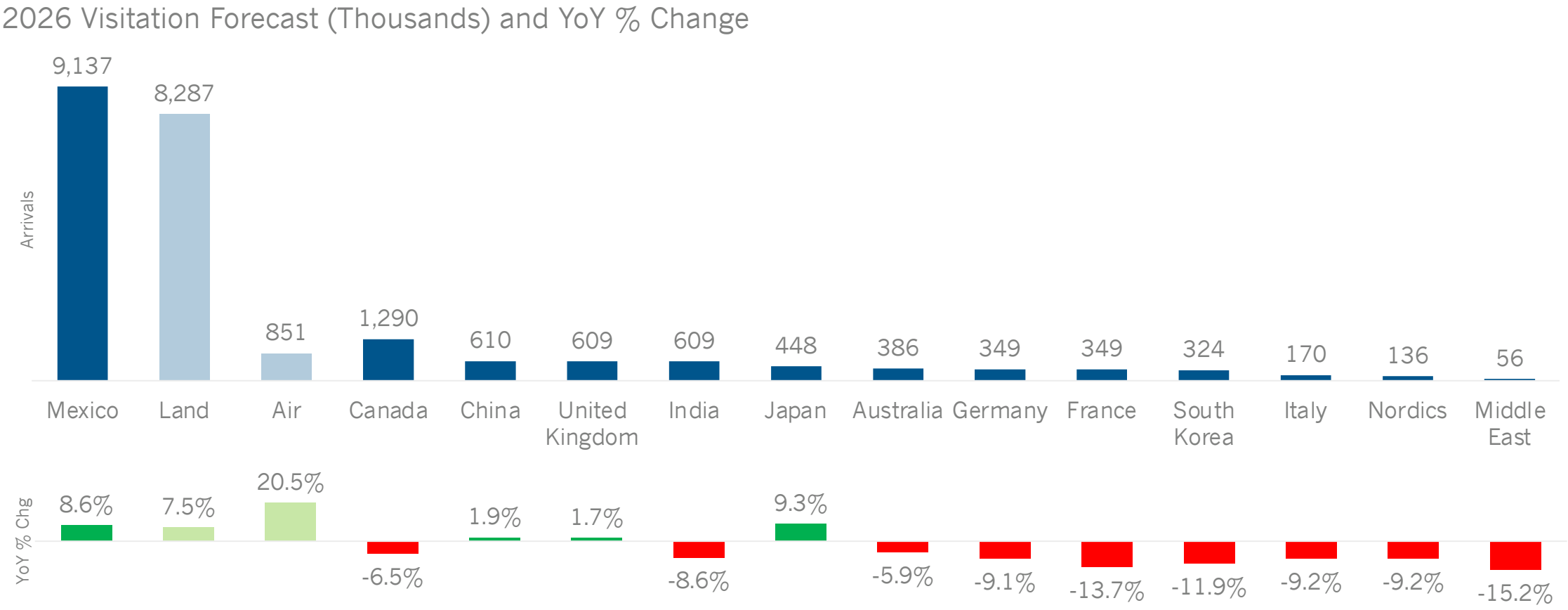
The chart below shows the current travel international spending forecast and annual growth rate.



Source: Tourism Economics (September 2026)

2026 Visitation Forecast: International Markets

The table below shows the international visitation forecast for California broken out by international market.



Source: Tourism Economics (September 2026)

2026 Downside Forecast: International Markets

The table below shows the international visitation downside forecast compared to baseline forecast by international market.

International Visitation		
	2026 Baseline	2026 Downside
Total	**2.4%**	**0.0%**
Mexico	8.6%	6.5%
Land	*7.5%*	*5.9%*
Air	*20.5%*	*12.3%*
Canada	-6.5%	-10.3%
China	1.9%	-1.2%
India	-8.6%	-10.0%
United Kingdom	1.7%	0.7%
Japan	9.3%	8.2%
Australia	-5.9%	-8.7%
Germany	-9.1%	-11.9%
France	-13.7%	-17.6%
South Korea	-11.9%	-14.6%
Italy	-9.2%	-11.0%
Nordics	-9.2%	-11.6%
Middle East	-15.2%	-18.5%

Source: Tourism Economics (September 2026)

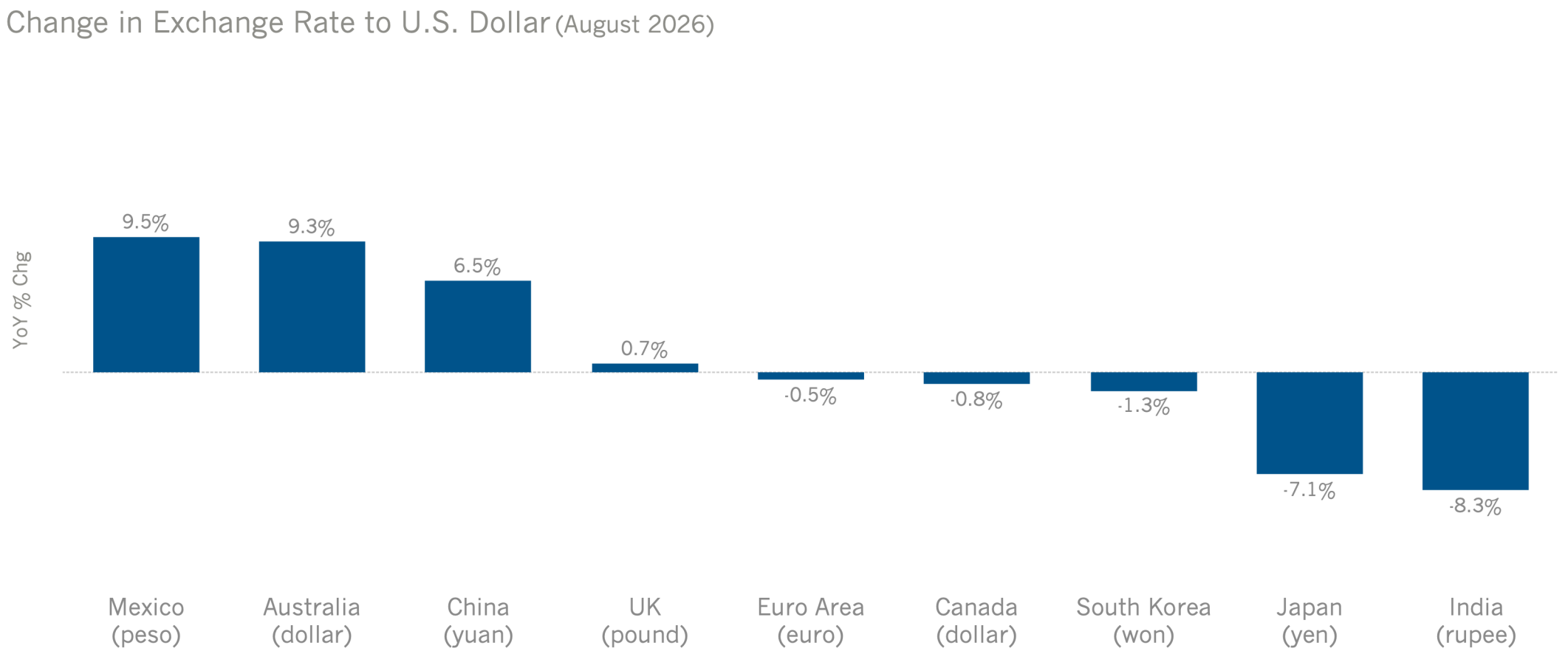
International Indicators:

Exchange Rate

- Foreign currencies to U.S. dollar

Exchange Rates

The chart below shows the year-over-year change in the exchange rate of the foreign currency to the U.S. dollar.



Source: X-Rate

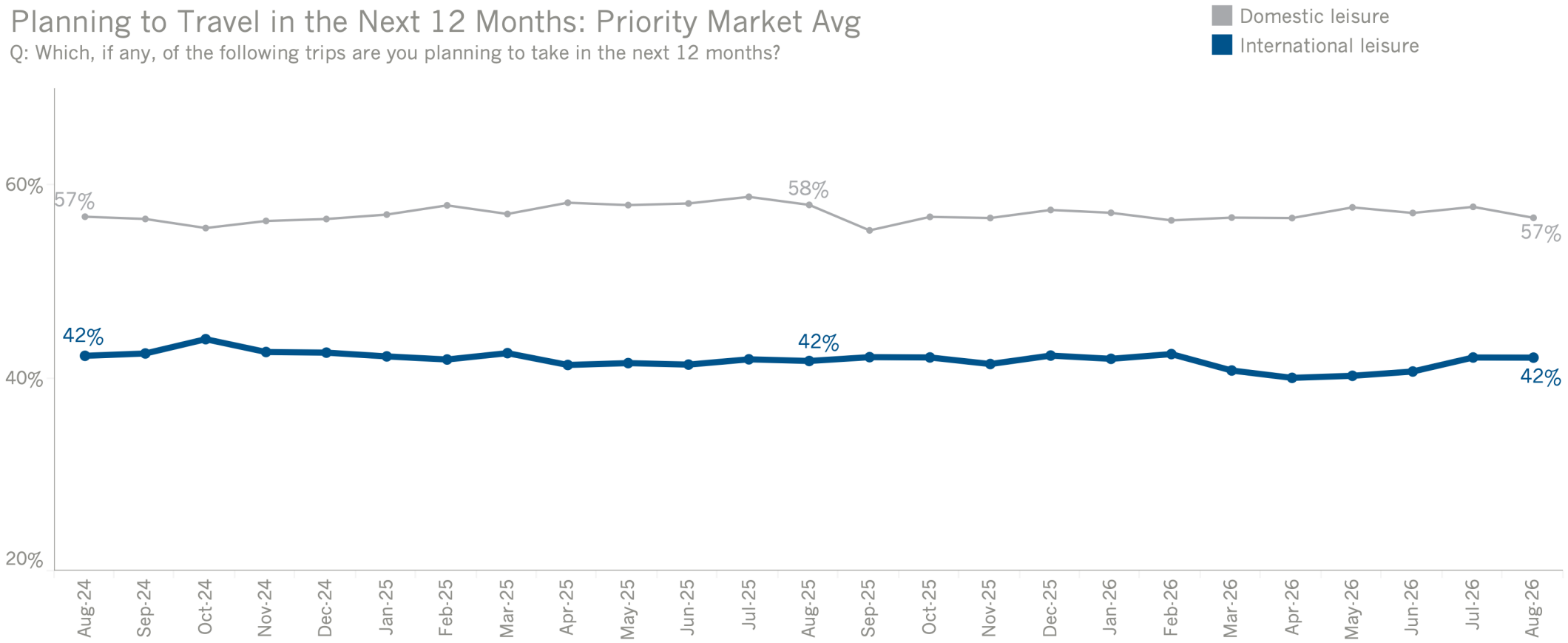
International Indicators:

Consumer Sentiment

- Travel planned
- Barriers to travel
- Considering travel to U.S. & California

Travel Planned

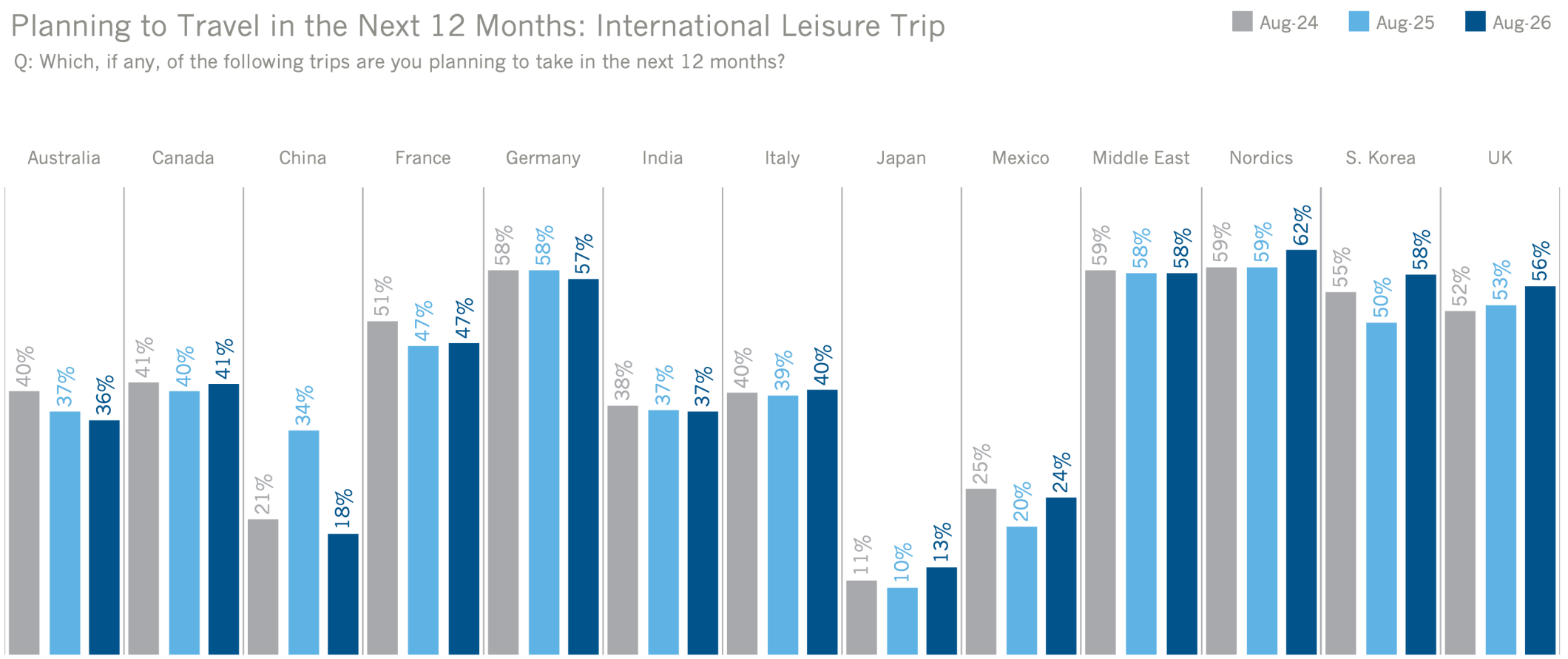
The chart below shows types of travel planned in the next 12 months among international market consumers.



Source: YouGov

Travel Planned (International Leisure)

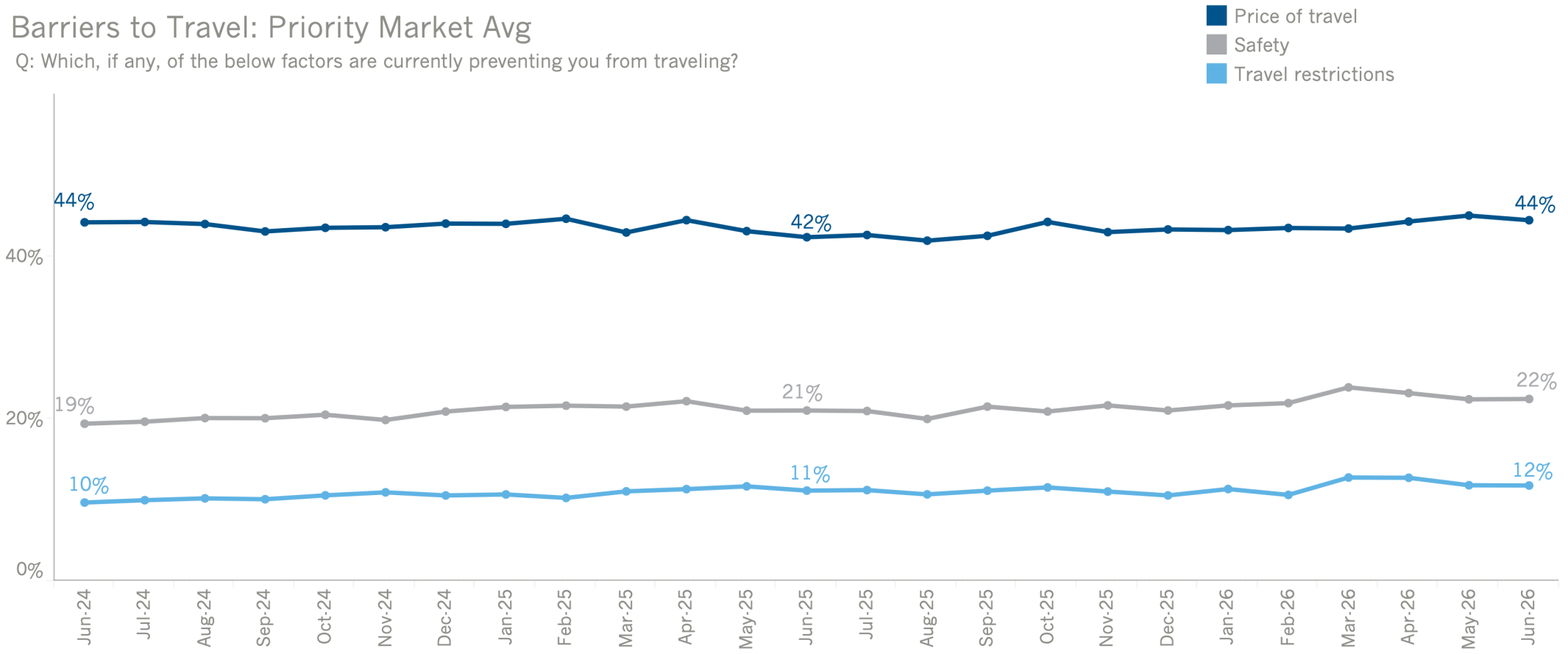
The chart below shows international leisure travel planned in the next 12 months by market.



Source: YouGov

Barriers to Travel

The chart below shows perceived barriers to travel among international consumers from priority markets.

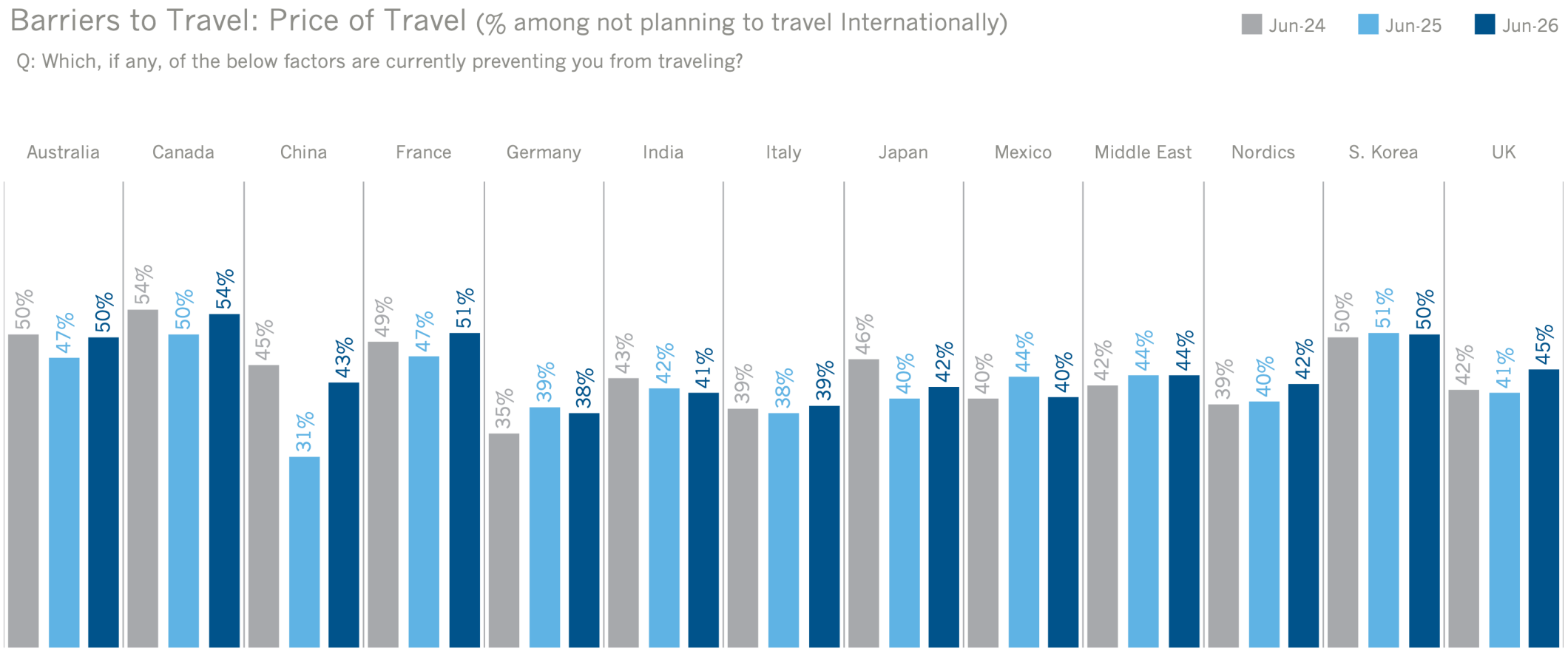


*No July/August update due to recent changes in methodology implemented by YouGov.

Source: YouGov

Barriers to Travel (Price)

The chart below shows price of travel as a barrier among international consumers from priority markets.

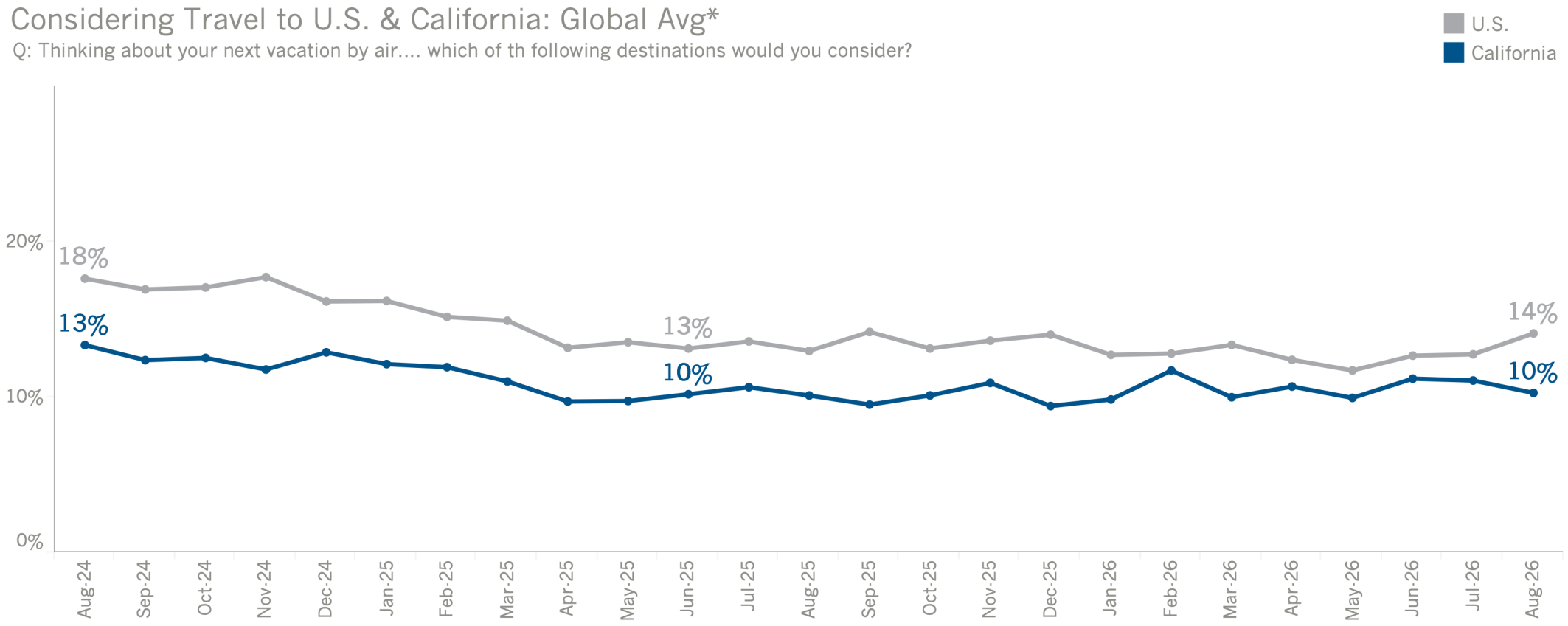


*No July/August update due to recent changes in methodology implemented by YouGov.

Source: YouGov

Travel Intent (to U.S. & California)

The chart below shows the percent of travelers considering travel to the U.S. and California in the next 12 months.

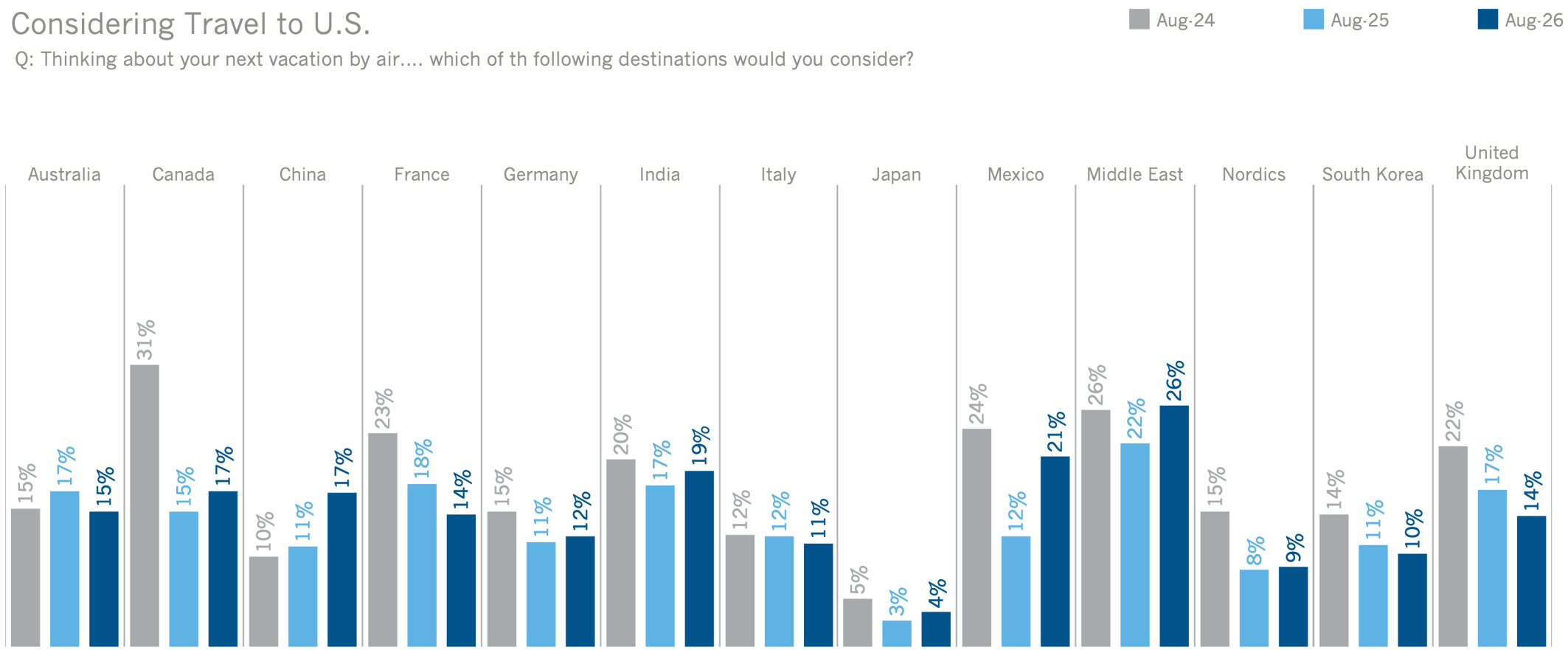


*Based on respondents in Australia, Canada, China, Germany, France, India, Italy, Mexico, Middle East, Nordics, South Korea, & UK

Source: YouGov

Travel Intent (to U.S.)

The chart below shows the percent of consumers in the market considering travel to the U.S. in the next 12 months.



Source: YouGov

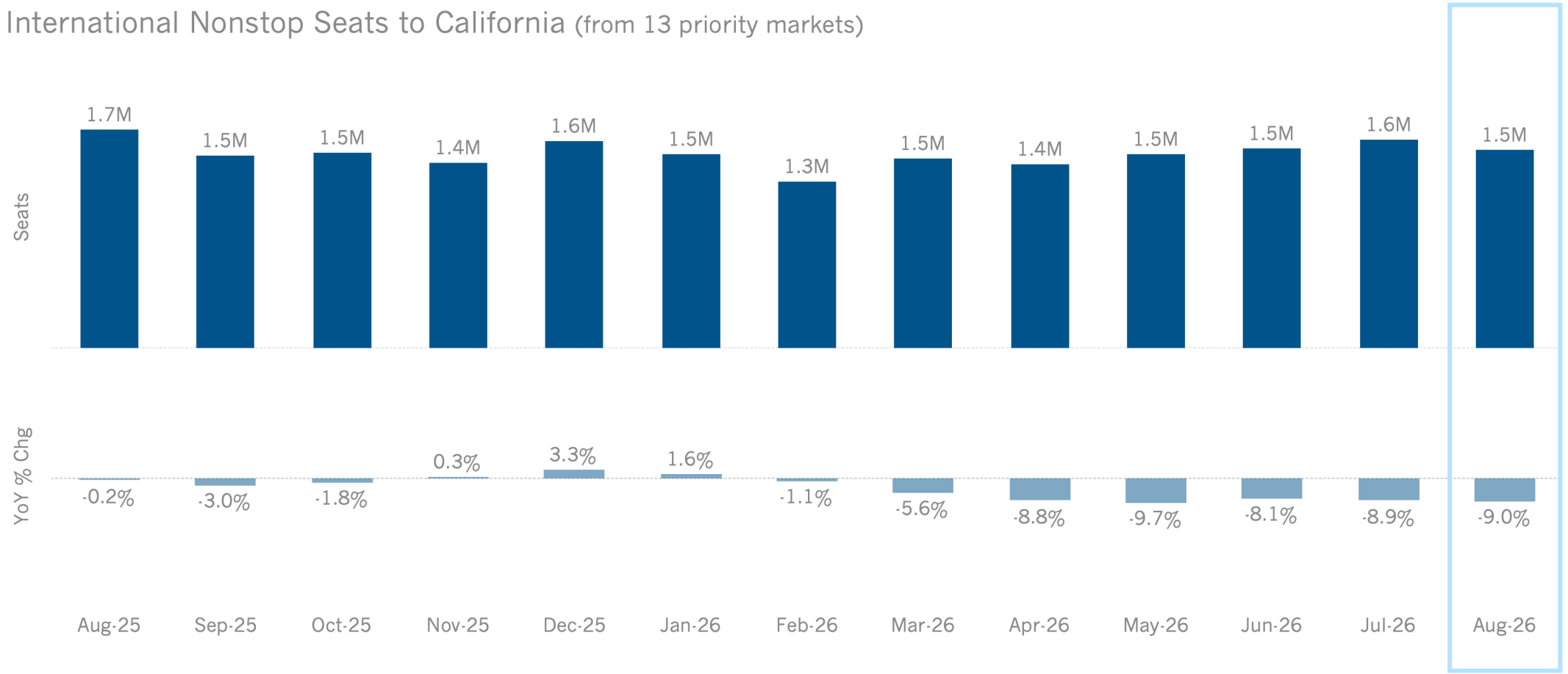
International Indicators:

Airlift & Arrivals

- International nonstop seats
- Nonresident arrivals

International Nonstop Seats

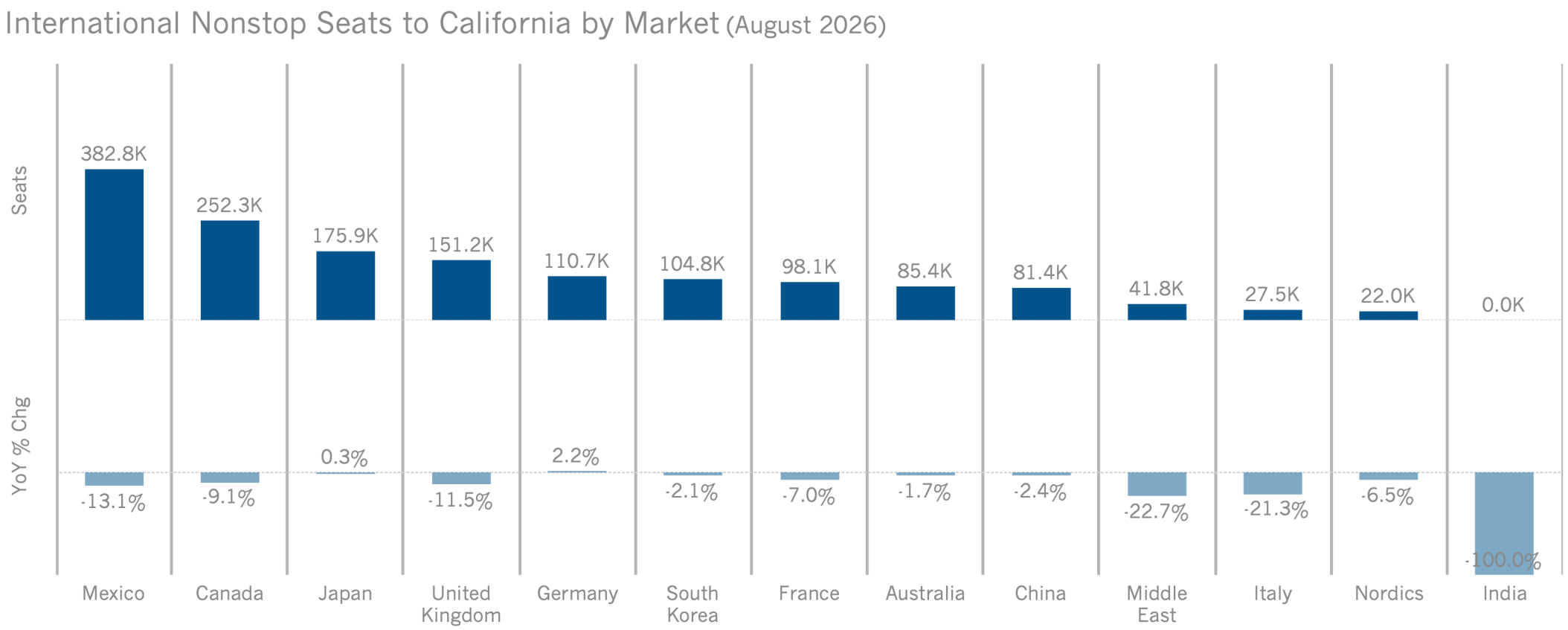
The chart below shows monthly international nonstop seats to California and percent change for 13 priority markets.



Source: Cirium

International Nonstop Seats by Market

The chart below shows nonstop seats to California by priority international market for the reporting month.



*Air India flights to California now have a re-fueling stop and are no longer categorized as nonstop.

Source: Cirium

International Nonstop Seats with YTD

The chart below shows nonstop seats to California by priority international markets for the reporting month.

International Nonstop Seats to California by Market (August 2026)

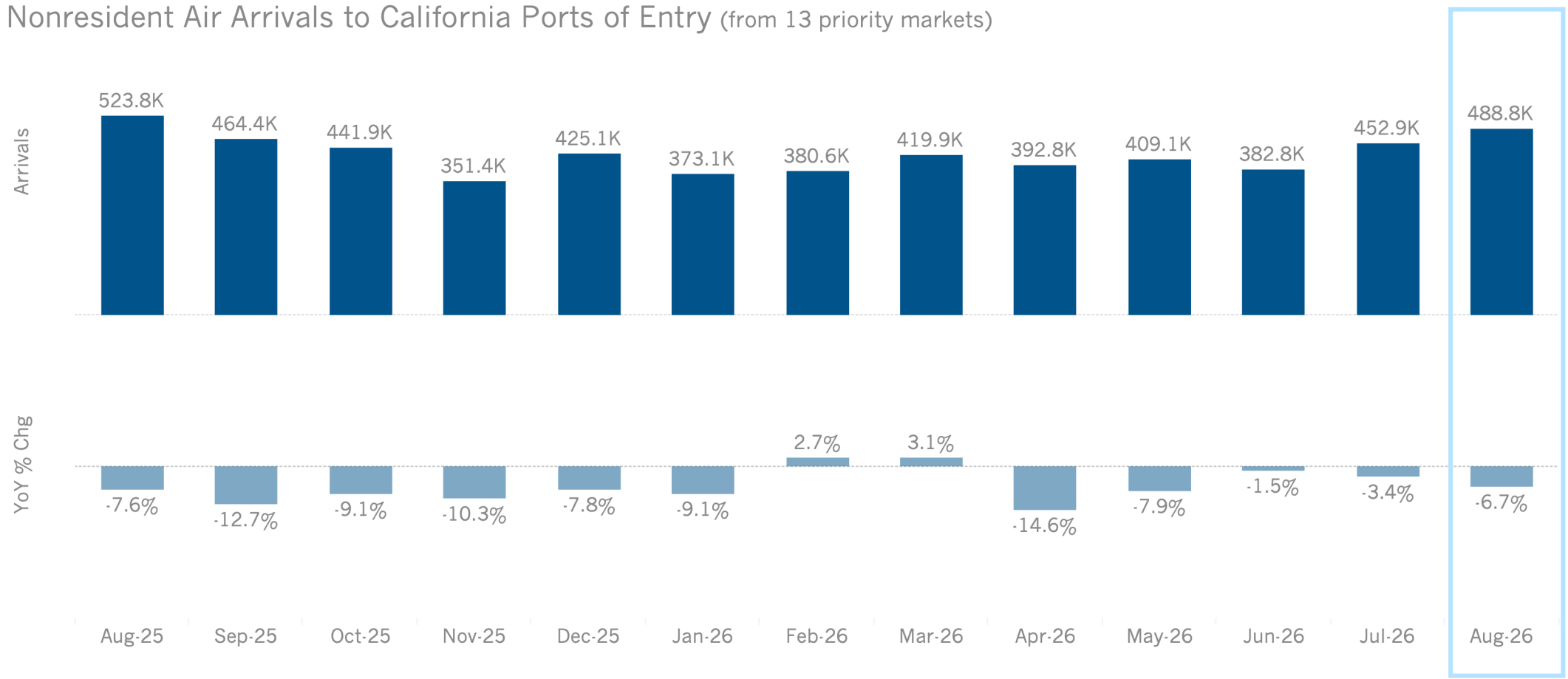
	Nonstop Seats (month)	YoY % Chg (month)	YoY % Chg (YTD)
Total Priority Markets	1,533.9K	-9.0%	-6.5%
Mexico	382.8K	-13.1%	-6.3%
Canada	252.3K	-9.1%	-11.8%
Japan	175.9K	0.3%	0.9%
United Kingdom	151.2K	-11.5%	-7.0%
Germany	110.7K	2.2%	1.1%
South Korea	104.8K	-2.1%	-4.4%
France	98.1K	-7.0%	-4.9%
Australia	85.4K	-1.7%	2.4%
China	81.4K	-2.4%	1.8%
Middle East	41.8K	-22.7%	-27.9%
Italy	27.5K	-21.3%	-12.3%
Nordics	22.0K	-6.5%	-4.4%
India	0.0K	-100.0%	-65.4%

*Air India flights to California now have a re-fueling stop and are no longer categorized as nonstop.

Source: Cirium

Nonresident Air Arrivals

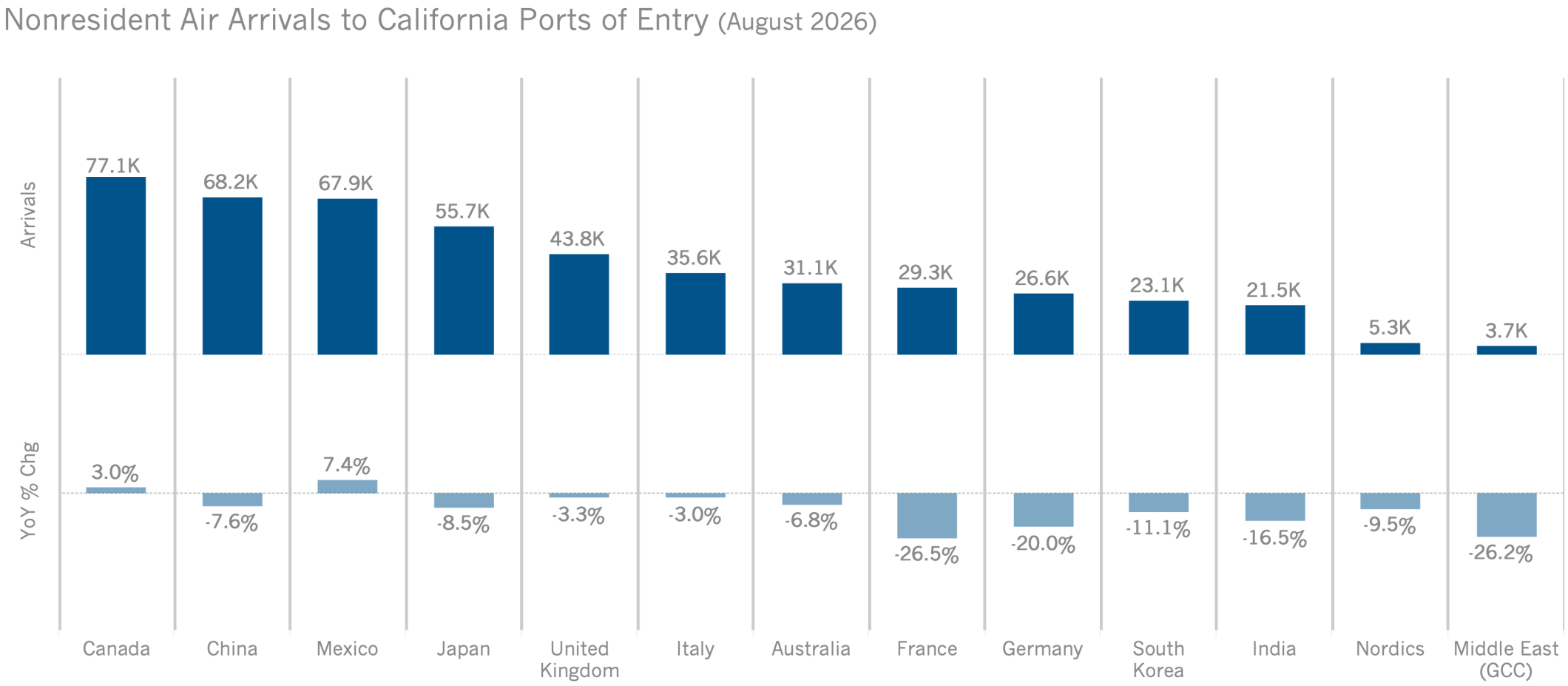
The chart below shows international nonresident air arrivals to any California port of entry by month and percent change.



Source: NTTO/CIC Research

Nonresident Air Arrivals by Market

The chart below shows nonresident air arrivals to any California port of entry by international market for the reporting month.



Source: NTTO/CIC Research

Nonresident Air Arrivals with YTD

The table below shows nonresident air arrivals to any California port of entry for the reporting month (with U.S. comparison).

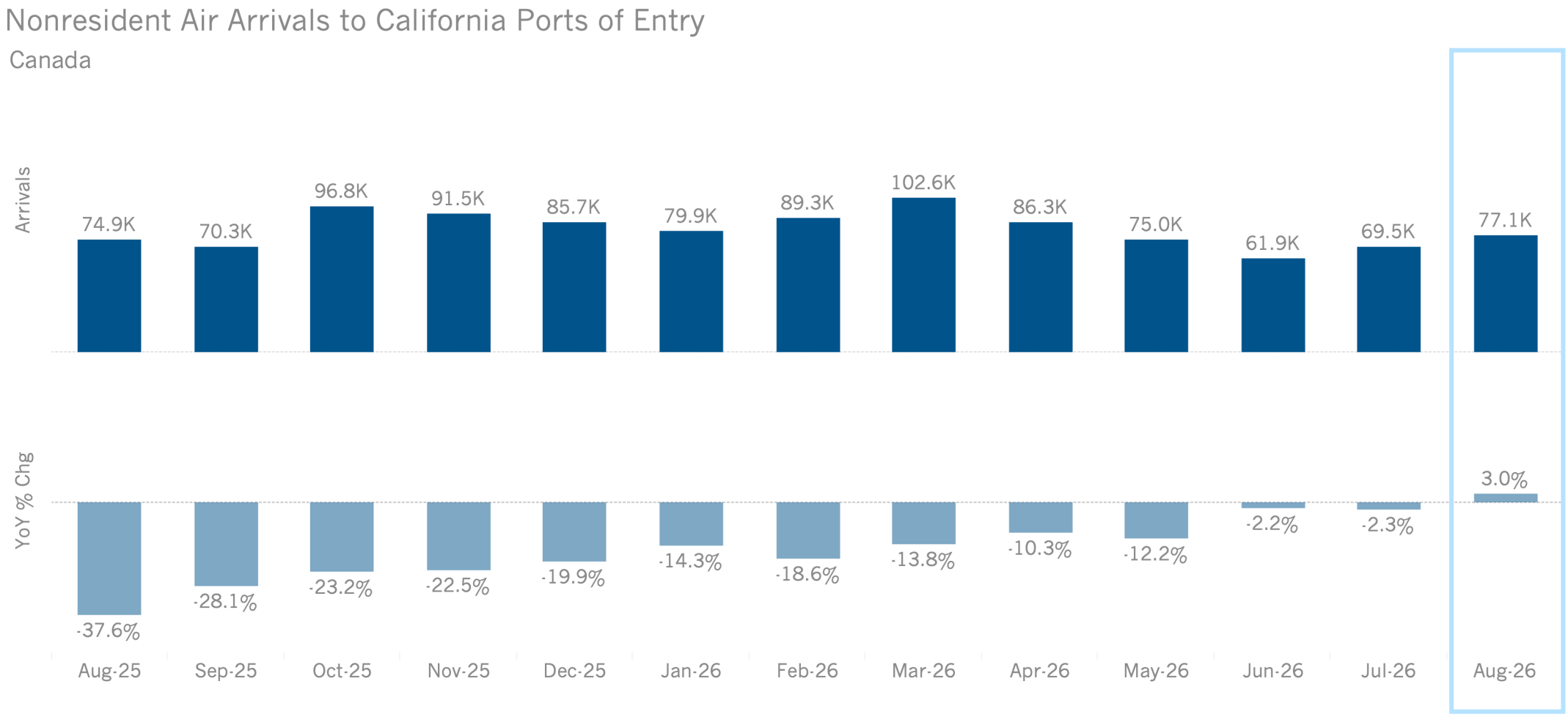
Nonresident Air Arrivals to California & U.S. Ports of Entry (August 2026)

	All California POEs			All U.S. POEs		
Country	Arrivals (month)	YoY % Chg (month)	YoY % Chg (YTD)	Arrivals (month)	YoY % Chg (month)	YoY % Chg (YTD)
Total International	650.9K	-6.4%	-4.6%	3,605.7K	-7.2%	-5.1%
Total Overseas	505.9K	-9.3%	-5.4%	2,783.2K	-10.2%	-5.6%
Total Priority Markets	488.8K	-6.7%	-5.0%	2,318.7K	-6.8%	-6.3%
Canada	77.1K	3.0%	-10.0%	482.7K	4.7%	-9.0%
China	68.2K	-7.6%	-0.7%	162.7K	-7.6%	-1.6%
Mexico	67.9K	7.4%	10.0%	339.7K	4.8%	7.2%
Japan	55.7K	-8.5%	6.9%	219.9K	-6.7%	2.3%
United Kingdom	43.8K	-3.3%	-0.3%	351.1K	-6.2%	0.1%
Italy	35.6K	-3.0%	-7.7%	161.3K	-9.3%	-11.3%
Australia	31.1K	-6.8%	-6.9%	59.1K	-8.3%	-8.4%
France	29.3K	-26.5%	-20.4%	127.6K	-21.0%	-15.1%
Germany	26.6K	-20.0%	-11.5%	136.9K	-20.5%	-15.5%
South Korea	23.1K	-11.1%	-12.3%	98.9K	-27.2%	-19.5%
India	21.5K	-16.5%	-10.4%	115.5K	-14.6%	-12.2%
Nordics	5.3K	-9.5%	-15.8%	35.9K	-11.0%	-11.9%
Middle East (GCC)	3.7K	-26.2%	-27.0%	27.4K	-9.9%	-18.6%

Source: NTTO/CIC Research

Nonresident Air Arrivals (Canada)

The chart below shows international nonresident air arrivals from Canada to any California port of entry by month and percent change.



Source: NTTO/CIC Research

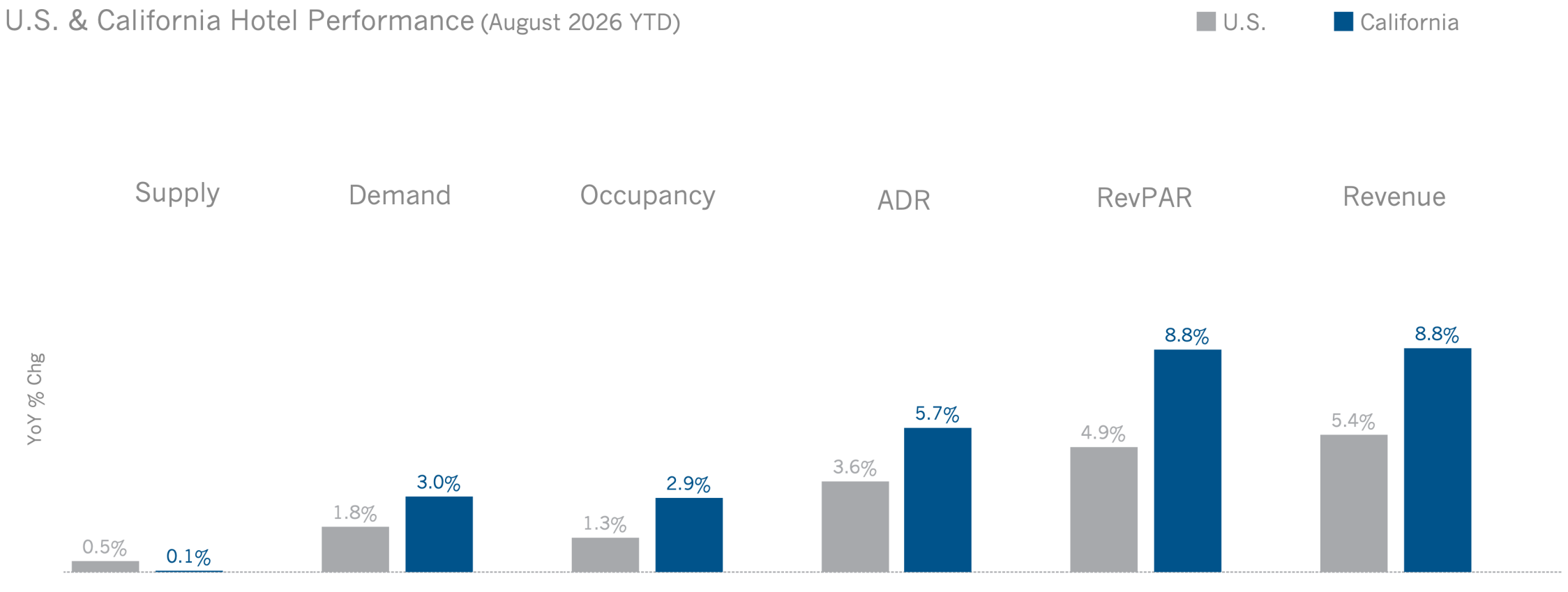
Appendix:

YTD Metrics

- Lodging Performance

U.S. & California Hotel Performance (YTD)

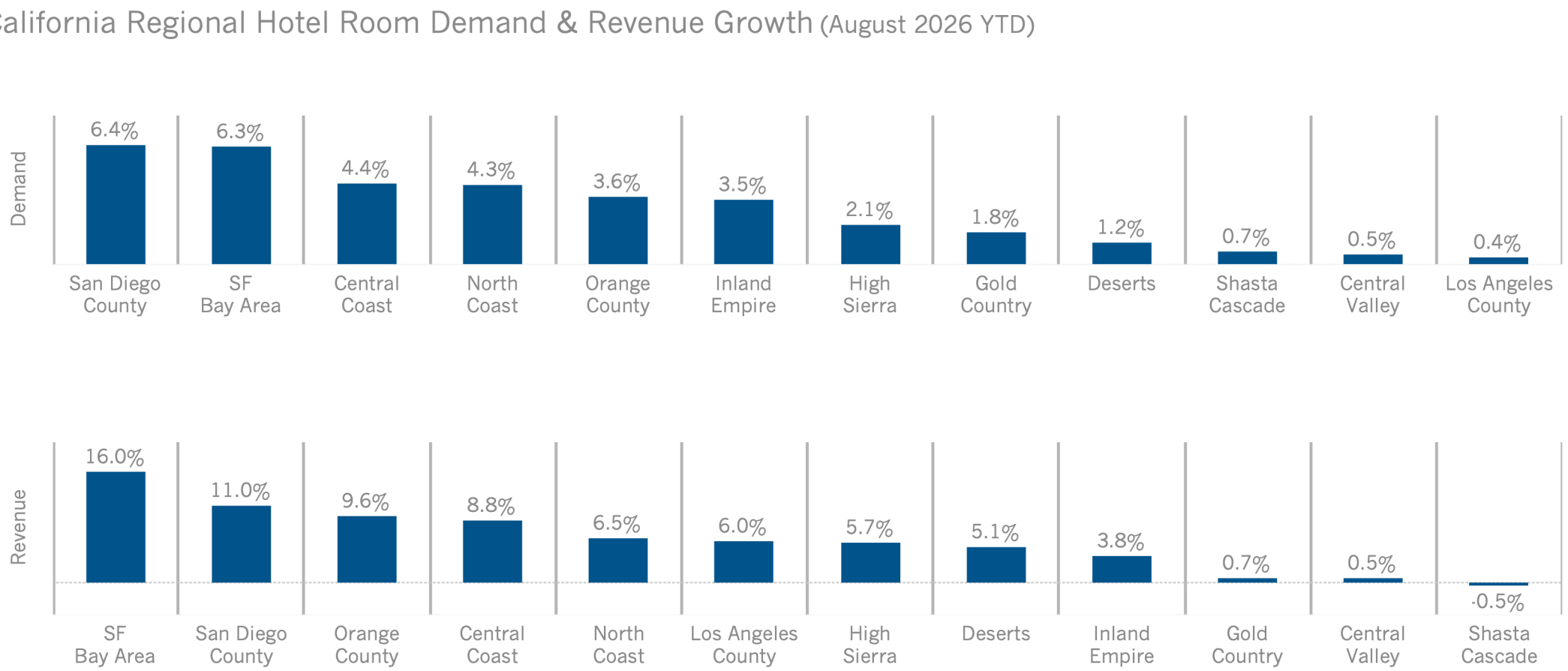
The chart below shows year-over-year performance for the U.S. and California for the reporting month year to date.



Source: CoStar

Regional Demand & Revenue Growth (YTD)

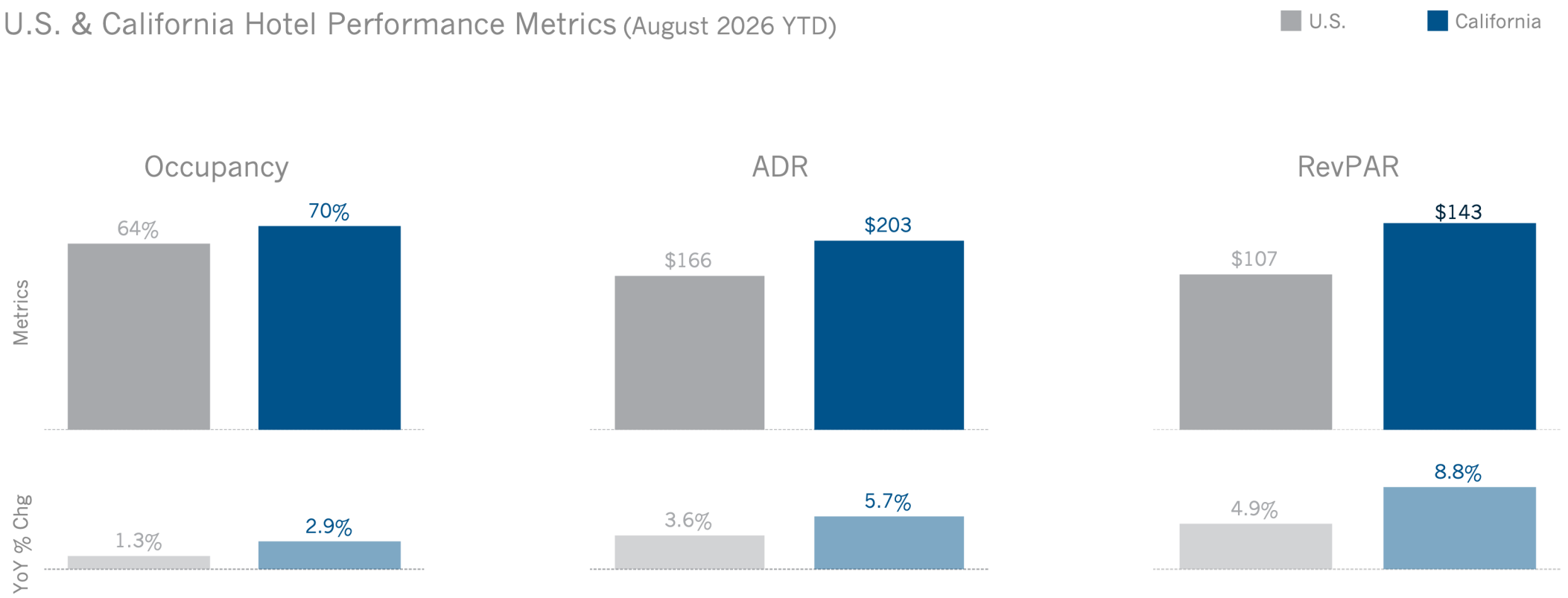
The chart below shows regional hotel room demand and revenue percent change to prior year.



Source: CoStar

U.S. & California Hotel Metrics (YTD)

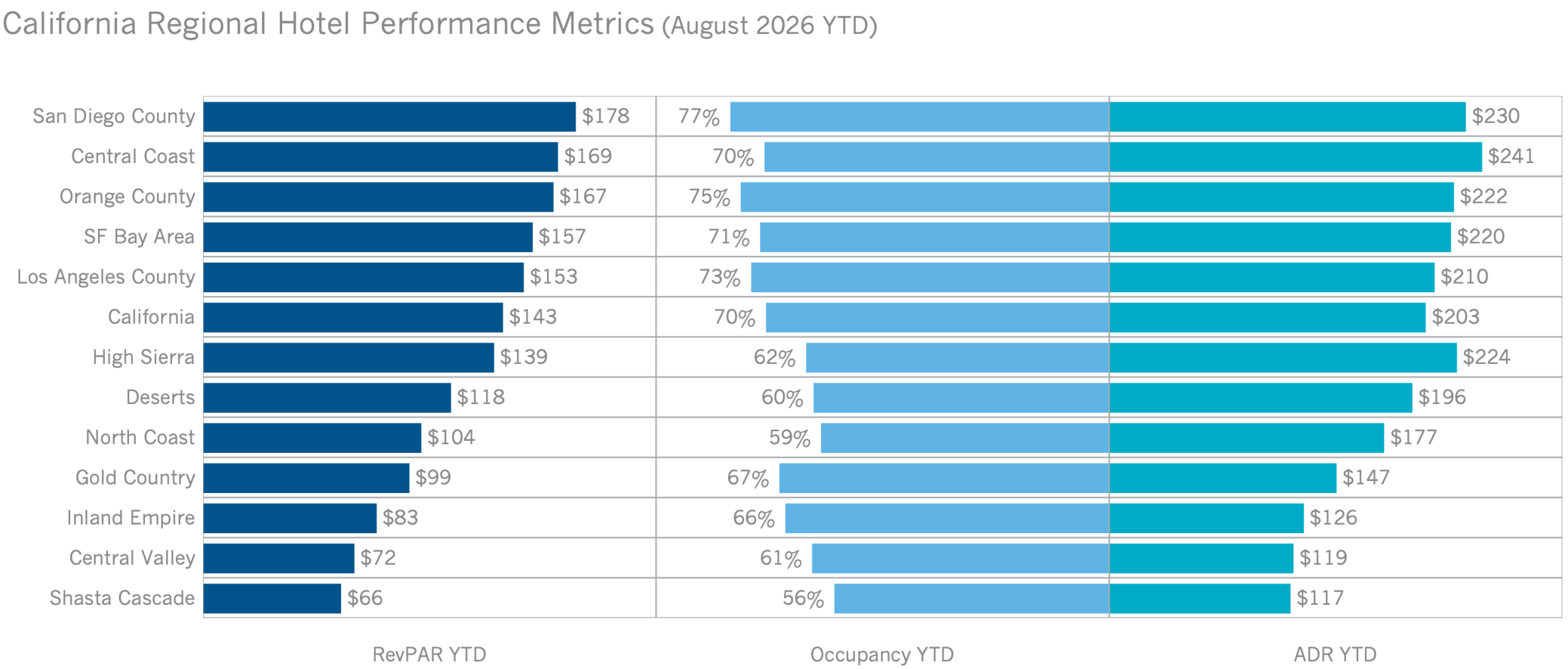
The charts below show key hotel metrics and percent change for the U.S. and California for year-to-date.



Source: CoStar

California Region Hotel Metrics (YTD)

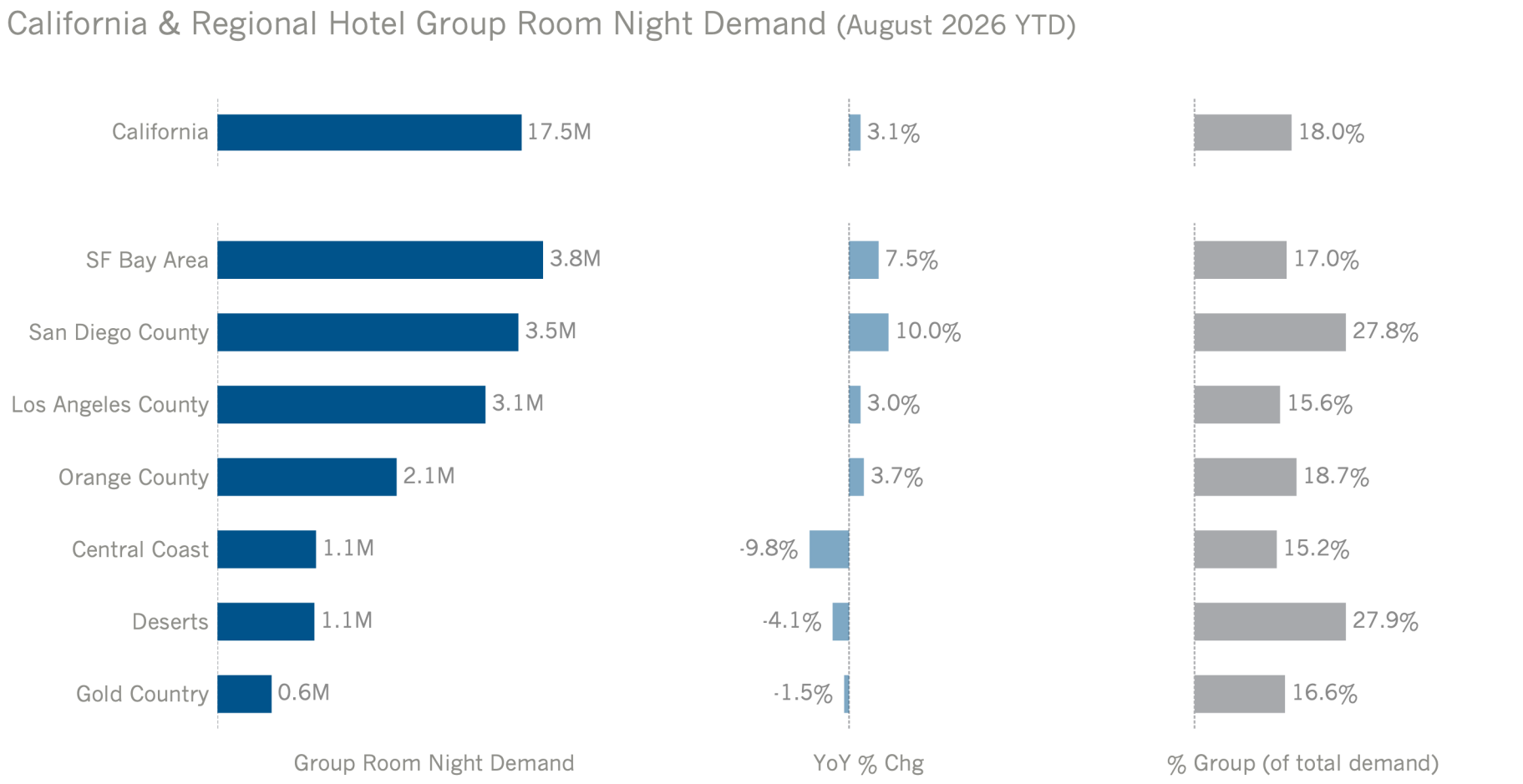
The charts below show key hotel metrics and percent change for the California tourism regions for year-to-date.



Source: CoStar

California Hotel Group Room Demand (YTD)

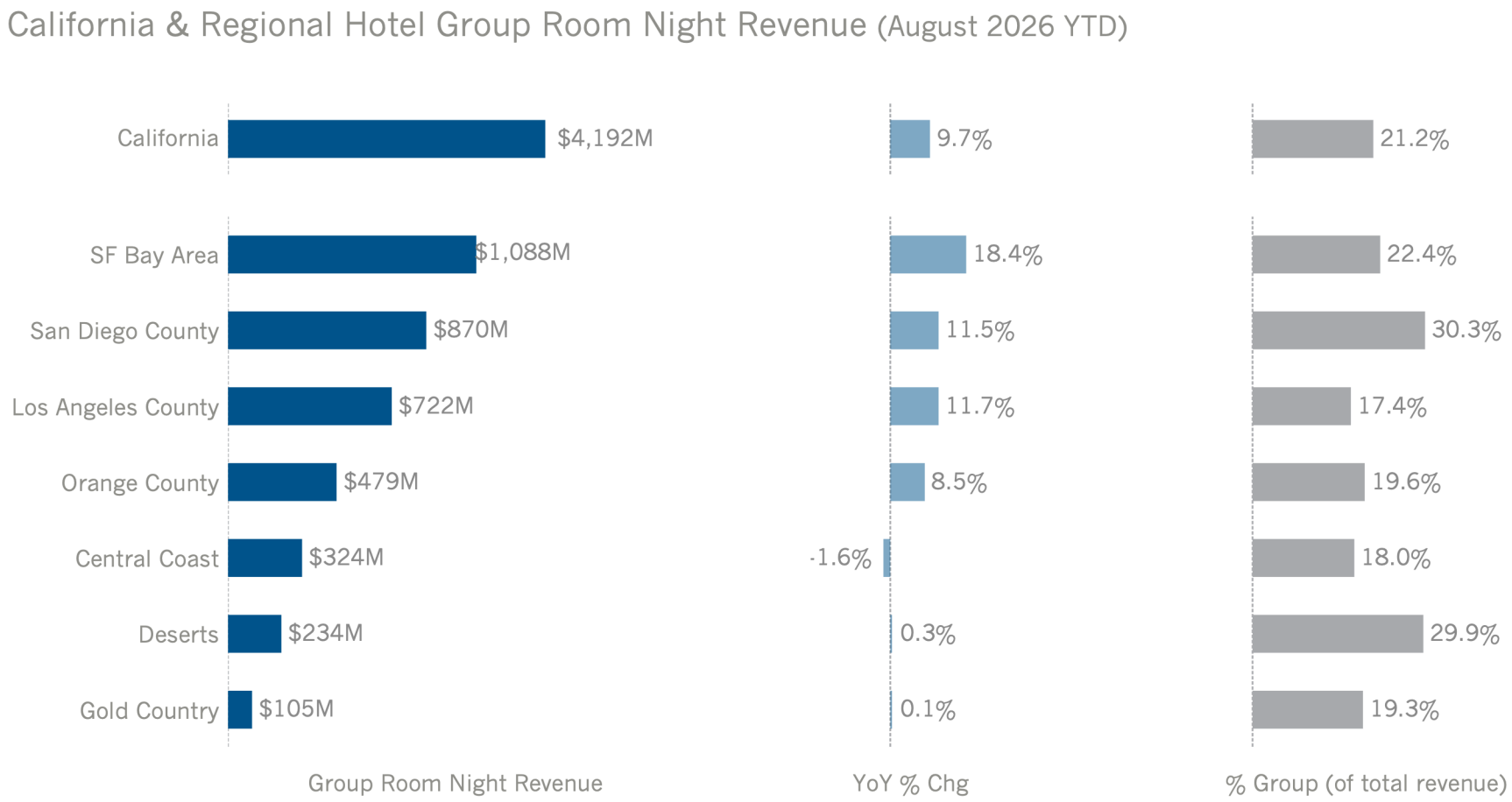
The chart below shows group room demand by market, percent change, & percent of total demand for year-to-date.



Source: CoStar

California Hotel Group Room Revenue (YTD)

The chart below shows group room revenue by market, percent change, & percent of total demand for year-to-date.



Source: CoStar